PRODUCTION BOOK · CHARACTERS + 5-SECOND BEATS

POV: You're 55, Your Wife Divorced You and Took Your $500,000…

— At Least, That's What She Thinks.

21 CHARACTERS · **168** BEATS · **13** STAGES · **~14 min** RUNTIME

Interactive: tap any link to jump, tick the boxes, type notes. Use your PDF app's bookmarks panel to navigate. Best in Adobe Acrobat Reader, Foxit, Xodo or a desktop browser so the boxes and notes save.

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STEP 1

Character prompts (generate these first)

The Protagonist

AGES 55–56 · MAIN CHARACTER

☐ Reference made

CHARACTER PROMPT

Character reference sheet of the protagonist: a man in his mid-fifties with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair with gray streaks at the temples, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines and soft crow's feet, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows with a few gray hairs, light salt-and-pepper stubble, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan. Show him five times side by side, full body front view, same face and hair in every pose, deadpan expression: (1) DIVORCE DAY: a slightly too-big charcoal suit with a loosened dark tie and scuffed shoes, (2) THE FALL: a plain black hoodie, gray sweatpants and worn sneakers, (3) ROCK BOTTOM: the black hoodie under a worn olive canvas coat, (4) THE RISE: a black quarter-zip pullover, dark jeans and clean boots, (5) COURT AGAIN: a dark tailored jacket over a black tee, a worn gold pen in his breast pocket. Plain light-gray background, outfit labels under each pose. Flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, semi-chibi proportions with an oversized head. He is always the darkest value in the frame.

Outfit by beat: suit 1–21 · hoodie 22–68 · hoodie + olive coat 69–77 and 91 · quarter-zip 92–134 · tailored jacket 135–168.

Appears in beats: 1, 2, 3, 4, 8, 9, 10, 11, 15, 17, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 27, 28, 29, 30, 31, 32, 33, 34, 35, 37, 38, 39, 41, 42, 47, 48, 49, 50, 51, 52, 53, 54, 55, 56, 57, 59, 61, 62, 64, 67, 68, 69, 72, 74, 75, 76, 77, 91, 92, 93, 94, 96, 97, 98, 99, 100, 101, 102, 103, 104, 105, 106, 107, 108, 109, 110, 111, 112, 113, 114, 115, 117, 118, 119, 120, 121, 124, 126, 127, 129, 133, 134, 135, 138, 140, 141, 142, 143, 144, 145, 146, 148, 149, 152, 153, 156, 157, 159, 160, 161, 162, 164, 165, 166, 167, 168

The Protagonist (younger)

AGE 31 · WALTER FLASHBACK ONLY

☐ Reference made

CHARACTER PROMPT

Character reference sheet, full body, front view and three-quarter view side by side, neutral standing pose, plain light-gray background, consistent proportions. The protagonist at age 31: a young man of thirty-one with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair with no gray, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, clean-shaven pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, slimmer, wearing a plain black crewneck sweater, dark jeans and sneakers, holding a sealed cream envelope. Desaturated, cold flashback tones. Flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, semi-chibi proportions with an oversized head.

Appears in beats: 81, 82, 83, 84, 85, 86, 87, 88, 89, 90

Renée

EX-WIFE · EARLY FIFTIES

☐ Reference made

CHARACTER PROMPT

Character reference sheet, full body, front view and three-quarter view side by side, neutral standing pose, plain light-gray background, consistent proportions. Renée: a slim, polished woman in her early fifties with a sleek shoulder-length honey-blonde bob, sharp cheekbones, thin arched eyebrows, pearl stud earrings and a tight, guarded expression. Show two outfits side by side: (1) COURT: a cream blazer over a white silk blouse, tan trousers, a structured maroon handbag, (2) NEW CHAPTER: a camel trench coat, oversized sunglasses pushed up on her head, gold jewelry, a designer tote. Outfit labels under each pose. Flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, semi-chibi proportions with an oversized head.

Court outfit in stages 1, 11 and 12 · new-chapter outfit in stages 3 and 10.

Appears in beats: 3, 7, 13, 16, 20, 43, 45, 46, 47, 127, 128, 129, 130, 131, 132, 133, 136, 139, 140, 153, 154, 155, 156, 159

Dana

DAUGHTER · 26

☐ Reference made

CHARACTER PROMPT

Character reference sheet, full body, front view and three-quarter view side by side, neutral standing pose, plain light-gray background, consistent proportions. Dana: a young woman of twenty-six with her father's dark curly hair pulled into a low bun, a small silver nose stud and big worried eyes, wearing a long mustard wool coat over a black turtleneck, jeans and ankle boots, car keys in her hand. Flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, semi-chibi proportions with an oversized head.

Coat buttoned in stage 5 · coat off at dinner in beat 121.

Appears in beats: 42, 58, 59, 60, 61, 62, 120, 121, 149, 163

Eli

SON · 16

☐ Reference made

CHARACTER PROMPT

Character reference sheet, full body, front view and three-quarter view side by side, neutral standing pose, plain light-gray background, consistent proportions. Eli: a lanky sixteen-year-old boy with messy dark curly hair falling over his eyes, a few freckles, earbuds around his neck, wearing a faded maroon hoodie, baggy cargo pants and scuffed skate shoes, phone in hand, a guarded teenage expression. Flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, semi-chibi proportions with an oversized head.

Appears in beats: 63, 65, 66, 67, 117, 118, 119, 148, 163

Walter

GRANDFATHER · RETIRED MACHINIST (FLASHBACK)

☐ Reference made

CHARACTER PROMPT

Character reference sheet, full body, front view and three-quarter view side by side, neutral standing pose, plain light-gray background, consistent proportions. Walter: a frail but sharp-eyed man in his late eighties with thin white hair combed back, deep wrinkles and large knuckly machinist's hands, wearing a worn brown button-up cardigan over a white undershirt and gray slacks, an old wristwatch. Show him standing and also propped up in a hospital bed. Desaturated, cold flashback tones. Flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, semi-chibi proportions with an oversized head.

Appears in beats: 78, 79, 80, 81, 82, 83, 84, 85, 86, 87

Thomas Hollis

TRUST LAWYER · 81

☐ Reference made

CHARACTER PROMPT

Character reference sheet, full body, front view and three-quarter view side by side, neutral standing pose, plain light-gray background, consistent proportions. Thomas Hollis: a stooped eighty-one-year-old lawyer with a bald spotted head, wispy white sideburns, round wire glasses and trembling hands, wearing an old-fashioned three-piece gray tweed suit with a pocket watch chain, holding a worn gold fountain pen. Flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, semi-chibi proportions with an oversized head.

Appears in beats: 93, 94, 101, 102, 103

Martin Hollis

THOMAS'S SON · TRUST LAWYER

☐ Reference made

CHARACTER PROMPT

Character reference sheet, full body, front view and three-quarter view side by side, neutral standing pose, plain light-gray background, consistent proportions. Martin Hollis: a neat man in his early fifties with short graying hair, a trimmed beard and a calm professional face, wearing a navy suit with a light-blue shirt and no tie, holding a thick manila trust folder. Flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, semi-chibi proportions with an oversized head.

Appears in beats: 94, 95, 96, 98, 99, 100, 101

Luis

FOREMAN · FLOORING COMPANY

☐ Reference made

CHARACTER PROMPT

Character reference sheet, full body, front view and three-quarter view side by side, neutral standing pose, plain light-gray background, consistent proportions. Luis: a broad-shouldered Latino man in his early forties with a short black buzz cut, a thick mustache and kind tired eyes, wearing a gray work polo with a small company logo, dusty work pants, knee pads and steel-toe boots, a tape measure on his belt. Flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, semi-chibi proportions with an oversized head.

Appears in beats: 34, 35, 37, 38, 116

The Judge

FAMILY COURT JUDGE · BOTH HEARINGS

☐ Reference made

CHARACTER PROMPT

Character reference sheet, full body, front view and three-quarter view side by side, neutral standing pose, plain light-gray background, consistent proportions. The judge: a composed Black woman in her early sixties with short natural gray hair, reading glasses on a beaded chain and a neutral, unreadable face, wearing a black judicial robe. Flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, semi-chibi proportions with an oversized head.

Appears in beats: 11, 16, 141, 150, 151, 152

The Court Clerk

COURTROOM 4B

☐ Reference made

CHARACTER PROMPT

Character reference sheet, full body, front view and three-quarter view side by side, neutral standing pose, plain light-gray background, consistent proportions. The court clerk: a bored middle-aged man with thinning brown hair and a cardigan over a short-sleeve dress shirt, a lanyard ID badge, holding a stack of yellow-tabbed papers and a cheap blue pen with a chewed cap. Flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, semi-chibi proportions with an oversized head.

Appears in beats: 4, 5, 9, 21, 147

Renée's First Lawyer

DIVORCE HEARING

☐ Reference made

CHARACTER PROMPT

Character reference sheet, full body, front view and three-quarter view side by side, neutral standing pose, plain light-gray background, consistent proportions. Renée's first lawyer: a heavyset man in his sixties with slicked-back silver hair and a

satisfied smirk, wearing a gray pinstripe suit and red tie, holding a leather briefcase. Flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, semi-chibi proportions with an oversized head.
Appears in beats: 7, 11, 16

Renée's New Lawyer
SECOND HEARING

☐ Reference made

CHARACTER PROMPT
Character reference sheet, full body, front view and three-quarter view side by side, neutral standing pose, plain light-gray background, consistent proportions. Renée's new lawyer: a sharp, confident man in his early thirties with a slick undercut, clean-shaven, wearing an expensive fitted black suit, a slim silver tie and a gleaming watch, gesturing mid-argument. Flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, semi-chibi proportions with an oversized head.
Appears in beats: 136, 137, 138, 139

Your Lawyer
SECOND HEARING

☐ Reference made

CHARACTER PROMPT
Character reference sheet, full body, front view and three-quarter view side by side, neutral standing pose, plain light-gray background, consistent proportions. His lawyer: a quiet, thin older man in his late sixties with a white goatee and half-moon glasses, wearing a rumpled brown suit, holding a folder of trust documents and receipts. Flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, semi-chibi proportions with an oversized head.
Appears in beats: 142, 147

Renée's Sister
COURT AND PORTUGAL

☐ Reference made

CHARACTER PROMPT
Character reference sheet, full body, front view and three-quarter view side by side, neutral standing pose, plain light-gray background, consistent proportions. Renée's sister: a woman in her late forties with big teased auburn hair, heavy makeup and a judgmental arched brow, wearing a leopard-print blouse and gold hoop earrings. Flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, semi-chibi proportions with an oversized head.
Appears in beats: 12, 46

Greg
OLD GOLF PARTNER

☐ Reference made

CHARACTER PROMPT
Character reference sheet, full body, front view and three-quarter view side by side, neutral standing pose, plain light-gray background, consistent proportions. Greg: a tanned, fit man in his late fifties with perfect white hair and very white teeth, wearing a pastel golf polo, khaki shorts and a visor, car keys swinging on his finger. Flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, semi-chibi proportions with an oversized head.
Appears in beats: 51, 52, 114

The Hardware Store Clerk

HARDWARE STORE

☐ Reference made

CHARACTER PROMPT

Character reference sheet, full body, front view and three-quarter view side by side, neutral standing pose, plain light-gray background, consistent proportions. The hardware store clerk: a chubby man in his forties with a red beard and a backwards cap, wearing a rust-orange store apron over a flannel shirt, a pencil behind his ear. Flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, semi-chibi proportions with an oversized head.

Appears in beats: 50, 113

The Church Woman

SUNDAY SERVICE

☐ Reference made

CHARACTER PROMPT

Character reference sheet, full body, front view and three-quarter view side by side, neutral standing pose, plain light-gray background, consistent proportions. The church woman: a petite woman in her seventies with a silver perm, a pastel floral dress, a small pearl brooch and a syrupy pitying smile, clutching a hymnal. Flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, semi-chibi proportions with an oversized head.

Appears in beats: 53, 54, 158

The Landlord

CALLOWAY STREET

☐ Reference made

CHARACTER PROMPT

Character reference sheet, full body, front view and three-quarter view side by side, neutral standing pose, plain light-gray background, consistent proportions. The landlord: a pot-bellied man in his sixties with a comb-over and a gray mustache, wearing a stained white undershirt under an open short-sleeve plaid shirt, a ring of keys on his belt. Flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, semi-chibi proportions with an oversized head.

Appears in beats: 70, 106, 107

Eli's Friend

THE DROP-OFF

☐ Reference made

CHARACTER PROMPT

Character reference sheet, full body, front view and three-quarter view side by side, neutral standing pose, plain light-gray background, consistent proportions. Eli's friend: a cocky sixteen-year-old boy with bleached tips in his hair, wearing a varsity jacket and a gold chain, leaning out of a small car's driver's window, smirking. Flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, semi-chibi proportions with an oversized head.

Appears in beats: 65

The Process Server

THE PORCH

☐ Reference made

CHARACTER PROMPT

Character reference sheet, full body, front view and three-quarter view side by side, neutral standing pose, plain light-gray background, consistent proportions. The process server: a stocky expressionless man in his forties with a shaved head, wearing a navy windbreaker and jeans, holding out a large manila envelope. Flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean

black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, semi-chibi proportions with an oversized head.
Appears in beats: 134

STAGE 1 · BEATS 1–21

Courtroom 4B

Age 55 · The signature

Beat 1 00:00 · ~5.9s · The Protagonist

“Courtroom 4B smells like carpet cleaner and old coffee. It's 9:52 on a Tuesday morning in May.”

IMAGE PROMPT

A dated family courtroom labeled 4B on a brass plaque by the door, beige carpet with coffee stains, a paper coffee cup on a wooden table, a wall clock reading 9:52, the protagonist seated alone at the respondent's table. The protagonist is a man in his mid-fifties with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair with gray streaks at the temples, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines and soft crow's feet, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows with a few gray hairs, light salt-and-pepper stubble, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a slightly too-big charcoal suit with a loosened dark tie, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: wide establishing one-point perspective shot down the aisle, protagonist off-center right. Lighting: harsh cool fluorescent courtroom light with a faint flicker, blue-gray shadows. Mood: stale, bureaucratic, heavy.

Camera: wide establishing one-point perspective shot down the aisle, protagonist off-center right · **Lighting:** harsh cool fluorescent courtroom light with a faint flicker, blue-gray shadows · **Mood:** stale, bureaucratic, heavy · **Action:** sitting stiffly, staring at the table

☐ Image made

Beat 2 00:05 · ~5.9s · The Protagonist

“You are fifty-five years old, sitting at a wooden table with a crack running through the varnish.”

IMAGE PROMPT

The protagonist sitting at a scratched wooden courtroom table with a long crack running through the varnish, his hands folded on top of it, a small brass nameplate reading RESPONDENT. The protagonist is a man in his mid-fifties with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair with gray streaks at the temples, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines and soft crow's feet, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows with a few gray hairs, light salt-and-pepper stubble, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a slightly too-big charcoal suit with a loosened dark tie, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium shot from across the table. Lighting: harsh cool fluorescent courtroom light with a faint flicker, blue-gray shadows. Mood: tired, exposed.

Camera: medium shot from across the table · **Lighting:** harsh cool fluorescent courtroom light with a faint flicker, blue-gray shadows · **Mood:** tired, exposed · **Action:** tracing the crack in the varnish with one finger

☐ Image made

Beat 3 00:11 · ~7.3s · The Protagonist, Renée

“Across the aisle, Renée doesn't look at you. Twenty-nine years of marriage, and she's found something very interesting on the ceiling.”

IMAGE PROMPT

Split courtroom aisle: the protagonist at his table on the left, Renée at the petitioner's table on the right staring up at the ceiling tiles, an empty aisle between them like a border. The protagonist is a man in his mid-fifties with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair with gray streaks at the temples, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines and soft crow's feet, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows with a few gray hairs, light salt-and-pepper stubble, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a slightly too-big charcoal suit with a loosened dark tie, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: Renée is a slim, polished woman in her early fifties with a sleek honey-blonde bob and pearl stud earrings, wearing a cream blazer over a white silk blouse. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: wide symmetrical shot down the aisle. Lighting: harsh cool fluorescent courtroom light with a faint flicker, blue-gray shadows. Mood: cold, distant.

Camera: wide symmetrical shot down the aisle · **Lighting:** harsh cool fluorescent courtroom light with a faint flicker, blue-gray shadows · **Mood:** cold, distant · **Action:** Renée looking at the ceiling, the protagonist looking at her

☐ Image made

Beat 4 00:19 · ~6.3s · The Protagonist, The Court Clerk

“The clerk slides a stack of paper toward you. Forty-one pages. A yellow tab everywhere your name goes.”

IMAGE PROMPT

The court clerk sliding a tall stack of paper toward the protagonist, the pages bristling with bright yellow sign-here tabs, a cover page reading 41 PAGES. The protagonist is a man in his mid-fifties with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair with gray streaks at the temples, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines and soft crow's feet, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows with a few gray hairs, light salt-and-pepper stubble, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a slightly too-big charcoal suit with a loosened dark tie, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: The court clerk is a bored middle-aged man with thinning brown hair, a cardigan and a lanyard badge. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: over-the-shoulder shot from behind the protagonist. Lighting: harsh cool fluorescent courtroom light with a faint flicker, blue-gray shadows. Mood: clinical, overwhelming.

Camera: over-the-shoulder shot from behind the protagonist · **Lighting:** harsh cool fluorescent courtroom light with a faint flicker, blue-gray shadows · **Mood:** clinical, overwhelming · **Action:** the clerk pushing the stack forward

☐ Image made

Beat 5 00:25 · ~5.2s · The Court Clerk

“Then a pen. A cheap blue court pen with a chewed cap. Belonging to nobody.”

IMAGE PROMPT

Close-up insert of a cheap blue plastic court pen with a chewed cap rolling across the wooden table toward the camera, the clerk's hand withdrawing in the background. Character notes: The court clerk is a bored middle-aged man with thinning brown hair, a cardigan and a lanyard badge. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: extreme close-up insert, shallow depth. Lighting: harsh cool fluorescent courtroom light with a faint flicker, blue-gray shadows. Mood: small, humiliating.

Camera: extreme close-up insert, shallow depth · **Lighting:** harsh cool fluorescent courtroom light with a faint flicker, blue-gray shadows · **Mood:** small, humiliating · **Action:** the pen rolling to a stop

☐ Image made

Beat 6 00:30 · ~4.2s · Insert / establishing

“The house. Hers. The savings. Split. The business accounts. Frozen, then divided.”

IMAGE PROMPT

Three-panel split-screen infographic: a family house with a SOLD-style tag reading HERS, a savings passbook torn cleanly in half reading SPLIT, a business ledger wrapped in chains and a padlock reading FROZEN. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: flat graphic triptych, eye level. Lighting: harsh cool fluorescent courtroom light with a faint flicker, blue-gray shadows. Mood: cold, mechanical.

Camera: flat graphic triptych, eye level · **Lighting:** harsh cool fluorescent courtroom light with a faint flicker, blue-gray shadows · **Mood:** cold, mechanical · **Action:** each asset being taken apart

☐ Image made

Beat 7 00:34 · ~4.9s · Renée, Renée's First Lawyer

“When the lawyers finish the math, she walks out with a little over $500,000.”

IMAGE PROMPT

Renée's first lawyer adding numbers on a yellow legal pad, a big circled total reading $500,000, Renée standing behind him buttoning her cream blazer with a faint satisfied look. Character notes: Renée is a slim, polished woman in her early fifties with a sleek honey-blonde bob and pearl stud earrings, wearing a cream blazer over a white silk blouse; Renée's first lawyer is a heavyset man in his sixties with slicked-back silver hair and a smirk, wearing a gray pinstripe suit and red tie. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium shot, the legal pad in the foreground. Lighting: harsh cool fluorescent courtroom light with a faint flicker, blue-gray shadows. Mood: transactional, final.

Camera: medium shot, the legal pad in the foreground · **Lighting:** harsh cool fluorescent courtroom light with a faint flicker, blue-gray shadows · **Mood:** transactional, final · **Action:** the lawyer tapping the circled number

☐ Image made

Beat 8 00:39 · ~4.9s · The Protagonist

“You walk out with a 2014 pickup, a storage unit, and the legal fees.”

IMAGE PROMPT

The protagonist in a courthouse parking lot holding only a key ring: a dented 2014 pickup behind him, a small storage unit key tag reading UNIT 114, and a folded legal fees invoice sticking out of his pocket. The protagonist is a man in his mid-fifties with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair with gray streaks at the temples, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines and soft crow's feet, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows with a few gray hairs, light salt-and-pepper stubble, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a slightly too-big charcoal suit with a loosened dark tie, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium-wide shot, protagonist off-center left. Lighting: harsh cool fluorescent courtroom light with a faint flicker, blue-gray shadows. Mood: stripped, deflated.

Camera: medium-wide shot, protagonist off-center left · **Lighting:** harsh cool fluorescent courtroom light with a faint flicker, blue-gray shadows · **Mood:** stripped, deflated · **Action:** holding up the keys, looking at them

☐ Image made

Beat 9 00:44 · ~3.1s · The Protagonist, The Court Clerk

“Sign here, the clerk says. And here. And here.”

IMAGE PROMPT

The clerk pointing to yellow tabs one after another on the document while the protagonist holds the blue pen above the page. The protagonist is a man in his mid-fifties with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair with gray streaks at the temples, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines and soft crow's feet, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows with a few gray hairs, light salt-and-pepper stubble, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a slightly too-big charcoal suit with a loosened dark tie, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: The court clerk is a bored middle-aged man with thinning brown hair, a cardigan and a lanyard badge. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: high-angle shot over the table. Lighting: harsh cool fluorescent courtroom light with a faint flicker, blue-gray shadows. Mood: mechanical, repetitive.

Camera: high-angle shot over the table · **Lighting:** harsh cool fluorescent courtroom light with a faint flicker, blue-gray shadows · **Mood:** mechanical, repetitive · **Action:** the clerk's finger jabbing at each tab

☐ Image made

Beat 10 00:47 · ~2.4s · The Protagonist

“Your hand doesn't shake. That surprises you.”

IMAGE PROMPT

Extreme close-up of the protagonist's steady hand signing with the cheap blue pen, a calm straight signature on the line. The protagonist is a man in his mid-fifties with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair with gray streaks at the temples, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines and soft crow's feet, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows with a few gray hairs, light salt-and-pepper stubble, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a slightly too-big charcoal suit with a loosened dark tie, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close-up insert. Lighting: harsh cool fluorescent courtroom light with a faint flicker, blue-gray shadows. Mood: eerily calm.

Camera: close-up insert · **Lighting:** harsh cool fluorescent courtroom light with a faint flicker, blue-gray shadows · **Mood:** eerily calm · **Action:** signing without a tremor

☐ Image made

Beat 11 00:50 · ~5.2s · The Protagonist, The Judge, Renée's First Lawyer

“Everybody in this room thinks they're watching a man lose everything. Her lawyer thinks it.”

IMAGE PROMPT

The courtroom seen from behind the protagonist: the judge on the bench, Renée's lawyer and a few onlookers all looking at him with pity and mild boredom. The protagonist is a man in his mid-fifties with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair with gray streaks at the temples, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines and soft crow's feet, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows with a few gray hairs, light salt-and-pepper stubble, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a slightly too-big charcoal suit with a loosened dark tie, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: The judge is a composed Black woman in her early sixties with short natural gray hair and reading glasses on a beaded chain, wearing a black robe; Renée's first lawyer is a heavyset man in his sixties with slicked-back silver hair and a smirk, wearing a gray pinstripe suit and red tie. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: wide reverse shot from behind the protagonist's shoulder. Lighting: harsh cool fluorescent courtroom light with a faint flicker, blue-gray shadows. Mood: judged, isolated.

Camera: wide reverse shot from behind the protagonist's shoulder · **Lighting:** harsh cool fluorescent courtroom light with a faint flicker, blue-gray shadows · **Mood:** judged, isolated · **Action:** everyone watching him

☐ Image made

Beat 12 00:55 · ~2.8s · Renée's Sister

“Her sister in the second row thinks it.”

IMAGE PROMPT

Renée's sister in the second row of the gallery, arms folded, whispering behind her hand to the person beside her with a smug look. Character notes: Renée's sister is a woman in her late forties with big teased auburn hair, heavy makeup and a leopard-print blouse. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium shot of the gallery. Lighting: harsh cool fluorescent courtroom light with a faint flicker, blue-gray shadows. Mood: catty, smug.

Camera: medium shot of the gallery · **Lighting:** harsh cool fluorescent courtroom light with a faint flicker, blue-gray shadows · **Mood:** catty, smug · **Action:** whispering and smirking

☐ Image made

Beat 13 00:58 · ~2.1s · Renée

“Renée thinks it most of all.”

IMAGE PROMPT

Renée in profile at her table, chin lifted, a faint closed-lip smile of victory, her cream blazer perfectly pressed. Character notes: Renée is a slim, polished woman in her early fifties with a sleek honey-blonde bob and pearl stud earrings, wearing a cream blazer over a white silk blouse. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium close-up. Lighting: harsh cool fluorescent courtroom light with a faint flicker, blue-gray shadows. Mood: triumphant, cold.

Camera: medium close-up · **Lighting:** harsh cool fluorescent courtroom light with a faint flicker, blue-gray shadows · **Mood:** triumphant, cold · **Action:** adjusting her pearl earring

☐ Image made

Beat 14 01:00 · ~5.6s · Insert / establishing

“But there's an envelope in a lawyer's safe across town, in a name that isn't yours.”

IMAGE PROMPT

Cutaway: a dim lawyer's office across town at night, an old steel safe with its door slightly ajar revealing a cream envelope labeled in old-fashioned handwriting 'Walter J. Pruitt — Trust', dust motes in a thin beam of light. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: slow push-in medium shot on the safe. Lighting: a single warm desk lamp in a dark room, deep blue shadows. Mood: secret, patient.

Camera: slow push-in medium shot on the safe · **Lighting:** a single warm desk lamp in a dark room, deep blue shadows · **Mood:** secret, patient · **Action:** the envelope resting untouched

☐ Image made

Beat 15 01:05 · ~2.8s · The Protagonist

“And nobody in this room knows it exists.”

IMAGE PROMPT

The protagonist alone at his courtroom table, everyone else blurred and gray, a faint glowing outline of an envelope drawn above his head like a thought only he can see. The protagonist is a man in his mid-fifties with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair with gray streaks at the temples, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines and soft crow's feet, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows with a few gray hairs, light salt-and-pepper stubble, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a slightly too-big charcoal suit with a loosened dark tie, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium shot, protagonist centered and darker than everyone. Lighting: harsh cool fluorescent courtroom light with a faint flicker, blue-gray shadows. Mood: quietly loaded.

Camera: medium shot, protagonist centered and darker than everyone · **Lighting:** harsh cool fluorescent courtroom light with a faint flicker, blue-gray shadows · **Mood:** quietly loaded · **Action:** staring ahead, revealing nothing

☐ Image made

Beat 16 01:08 · ~2.8s · The Judge, Renée's First Lawyer, Renée

“Not the lawyers. Not the judge. Not her.”

IMAGE PROMPT

Three faces in a row with question marks crossed out above them: the judge, Renée's lawyer and Renée, each completely unaware. Character notes: The judge is a composed Black woman in her early sixties with short natural gray hair and reading glasses on a beaded chain, wearing a black robe; Renée's first lawyer is a heavyset man in his sixties with slicked-back silver hair and a smirk, wearing a gray pinstripe suit and red tie; Renée is a slim, polished woman in her early fifties with a sleek honey-blonde bob and pearl stud earrings, wearing a cream blazer over a white silk blouse. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: three-shot medium framing. Lighting: harsh cool fluorescent courtroom light with a faint flicker, blue-gray shadows. Mood: dramatic irony.

Camera: three-shot medium framing · **Lighting:** harsh cool fluorescent courtroom light with a faint flicker, blue-gray shadows · **Mood:** dramatic irony · **Action:** all three looking the other way

☐ Image made

Beat 17 01:11 · ~6.3s · The Protagonist

“Here's what nobody tells you about losing half your life at fifty-five. The divorce is the easy part.”

IMAGE PROMPT

Visual metaphor: the protagonist standing on a giant courtroom document where the word DIVORCE is printed small, while behind him a huge dark shadow labeled AFTER looms over the horizon. The protagonist is a man in his mid-fifties with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair with gray streaks at the temples, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines and soft crow's feet, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows with a few gray hairs, light salt-and-pepper stubble, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a slightly too-big charcoal suit with a loosened dark tie, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: wide symbolic shot. Lighting: harsh cool fluorescent courtroom light with a faint flicker, blue-gray shadows. Mood: ominous.

Camera: wide symbolic shot · **Lighting:** harsh cool fluorescent courtroom light with a faint flicker, blue-gray shadows · **Mood:** ominous · **Action:** looking back at the shadow

☐ Image made

Beat 18 01:17 · ~7.0s · The Protagonist

“It's a signature. It's ten minutes. It's what comes after that takes you apart, one quiet piece at a time.”

IMAGE PROMPT

Visual metaphor: the protagonist standing still while pieces of his life float away from him like puzzle pieces — a house key, a business sign, a family photo, a wedding ring. The protagonist is a man in his mid-fifties with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair with gray streaks at the temples, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines and soft crow's feet, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows with a few gray hairs, light salt-and-pepper stubble, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a slightly too-big charcoal suit with a loosened dark tie, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium-wide symbolic shot. Lighting: harsh cool fluorescent courtroom light with a faint flicker, blue-gray shadows. Mood: slow erosion.

Camera: medium-wide symbolic shot · **Lighting:** harsh cool fluorescent courtroom light with a faint flicker, blue-gray shadows · **Mood:** slow erosion · **Action:** watching the pieces drift off

☐ Image made

Beat 19 01:24 · ~5.9s · The Protagonist

“This is how you hit the bottom while the whole town watched you start over from nothing.”

IMAGE PROMPT

A small town main street seen from above, neighbors peeking from windows and doorways at the protagonist walking alone down the sidewalk carrying a single cardboard box. The protagonist is a man in his mid-fifties with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair with gray streaks at the temples, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines and soft crow's feet, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows with a few gray hairs, light salt-and-pepper stubble, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a slightly too-big charcoal suit with a loosened dark tie, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: high-angle wide shot. Lighting: harsh cool fluorescent courtroom light with a faint flicker, blue-gray shadows. Mood: public humiliation.

Camera: high-angle wide shot · **Lighting:** harsh cool fluorescent courtroom light with a faint flicker, blue-gray shadows · **Mood:** public humiliation · **Action:** walking with his head down

☐ Image made

Beat 20 01:30 · ~7.3s · Renée, The Protagonist

“And how, sixteen months later, she sat in this same courtroom asking for half of a fortune she never knew existed.”

IMAGE PROMPT

Teaser flash-forward split-screen: on the left Renée in the same courtroom months later pointing angrily, on the right a closed vault door with a glowing $ sign behind it. The protagonist is a man in his mid-fifties with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair with gray streaks at the temples, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines and soft crow's feet, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows with a few gray hairs, light salt-and-pepper stubble, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a slightly too-big charcoal suit with a loosened dark tie, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: Renée is a slim, polished woman in her early fifties with a sleek honey-blonde bob and pearl stud earrings, wearing a cream blazer over a white silk blouse. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: split-screen medium shot. Lighting: harsh cool fluorescent courtroom light with a faint flicker, blue-gray shadows. Mood: foreboding, intriguing.

Camera: split-screen medium shot · **Lighting:** harsh cool fluorescent courtroom light with a faint flicker, blue-gray shadows · **Mood:** foreboding, intriguing · **Action:** Renée pointing, the vault glowing

☐ Image made

Beat 21 01:38 · ~3.8s · The Protagonist, The Court Clerk

“You sign the last page. The clerk takes the pen back.”

IMAGE PROMPT

The clerk pulling the cheap blue pen back across the table while the protagonist's hand lingers on the final signed page. The protagonist is a man in his mid-fifties with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair with gray streaks at the temples, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines and soft crow's feet, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows with a few gray hairs, light salt-and-pepper stubble, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a slightly too-big charcoal suit with a loosened dark tie, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: The court clerk is a bored middle-aged man with thinning brown hair, a cardigan and a lanyard badge. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close-up over the table. Lighting: harsh cool fluorescent courtroom light with a faint flicker, blue-gray shadows. Mood: final, hollow.

Camera: close-up over the table · **Lighting:** harsh cool fluorescent courtroom light with a faint flicker, blue-gray shadows · **Mood:** final, hollow · **Action:** letting go of the paper

☐ Image made

STAGE 2 · BEATS 22–40

Calloway Street

Age 55 · The house and the businesses

Beat 22 01:41 · ~3.5s · The Protagonist

“The first thing nobody warns you about is the quiet.”

IMAGE PROMPT

The protagonist standing in a bare empty living room, a single cardboard box at his feet, dust floating in a shaft of gray light, total silence. The protagonist is a man in his mid-fifties with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair with gray streaks at the temples, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines and soft crow's feet, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows with a few gray hairs, light salt-and-pepper stubble, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a plain black hoodie, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: wide one-point perspective interior. Lighting: harsh cool light from a bare bulb and gray windows, blue-gray shadows. Mood: lonely, silent.

Camera: wide one-point perspective interior · **Lighting:** harsh cool light from a bare bulb and gray windows, blue-gray shadows · **Mood:** lonely, silent · **Action:** standing still in the middle of the room

☐ Image made

Beat 23 01:45 · ~5.2s · The Protagonist

“Three weeks later, you're standing in the doorway of a rented house on Calloway Street.”

IMAGE PROMPT

The protagonist in the doorway of an old rented house, a crooked street sign reading CALLOWAY ST on the corner, peeling paint and a rusted mailbox. The protagonist is a man in his mid-fifties with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair with gray streaks at the temples, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines and soft crow's feet, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows with a few gray hairs, light salt-and-pepper stubble, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a plain black hoodie, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium-wide shot from the yard looking up at the doorway. Lighting: harsh cool light from a bare bulb and gray windows, blue-gray shadows. Mood: bleak, new beginning.

Camera: medium-wide shot from the yard looking up at the doorway · **Lighting:** harsh cool light from a bare bulb and gray windows, blue-gray shadows · **Mood:** bleak, new beginning · **Action:** holding the doorframe, hesitating

☐ Image made

Beat 24 01:50 · ~6.6s · The Protagonist

“Built in 1961. $1,150 a month. The porch sags in the middle like it's tired of holding itself up.”

IMAGE PROMPT

Exterior of a tired 1961 ranch house with a badly sagging porch roof, a FOR RENT $1,150/MO sign still stuck in the dead lawn, overgrown weeds. The protagonist is a man in his mid-fifties with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair with gray streaks at the temples, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines and soft crow's feet, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows with a few gray hairs, light salt-and-pepper stubble, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a plain black hoodie, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: wide establishing shot, protagonist small on the porch steps. Lighting: harsh cool light from a bare bulb and gray windows, blue-gray shadows. Mood: worn, depressing.

Camera: wide establishing shot, protagonist small on the porch steps · **Lighting:** harsh cool light from a bare bulb and gray windows, blue-gray shadows · **Mood:** worn, depressing · **Action:** looking up at the sagging porch

☐ Image made

Beat 25 01:57 · ~7.0s · The Protagonist

“The kitchen has one working burner. The bathroom faucet drips every four seconds, and by the second night, you're counting.”

IMAGE PROMPT

A cramped old kitchen with a stove where only one burner glows, and through an open doorway a bathroom faucet dripping, a tally of four-second drips drawn in the air like counting marks. The protagonist is a man in his mid-fifties with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair with gray streaks at the temples, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines and soft crow's feet, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows with a few gray hairs, light salt-and-pepper stubble, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a plain black hoodie, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium shot, protagonist at the stove. Lighting: harsh cool light from a bare bulb and gray windows, blue-gray shadows. Mood: monotonous, sleepless.

Camera: medium shot, protagonist at the stove · **Lighting:** harsh cool light from a bare bulb and gray windows, blue-gray shadows · **Mood:** monotonous, sleepless · **Action:** staring at the drip, counting

☐ Image made

Beat 26 02:04 · ~4.9s · Insert / establishing

“There's a water stain on the bedroom ceiling. Brown. Shaped almost like a hand.”

IMAGE PROMPT

Close-up of a brown water stain on a cracked bedroom ceiling, the stain shaped almost exactly like an open human hand. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: low-angle close-up looking straight up. Lighting: harsh cool light from a bare bulb and gray windows, blue-gray shadows. Mood: eerie, quietly symbolic.

Camera: low-angle close-up looking straight up · **Lighting:** harsh cool light from a bare bulb and gray windows, blue-gray shadows · **Mood:** eerie, quietly symbolic · **Action:** the stain looming

☐ Image made

Beat 27 02:09 · ~6.6s · The Protagonist

“You lie on a mattress on the floor and stare at it. Twenty-nine years, you slept next to someone.”

IMAGE PROMPT

The protagonist lying on a bare mattress on the floor of a dim bedroom, staring up at the hand-shaped ceiling stain, an empty space on the mattress beside him. The protagonist is a man in his mid-fifties with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair with gray streaks at the temples, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines and soft crow's feet, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows with a few gray hairs, light salt-and-pepper stubble, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a plain black hoodie, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: top-down overhead shot. Lighting: harsh cool light from a bare bulb and gray windows, blue-gray shadows. Mood: lonely, hollow.

Camera: top-down overhead shot · **Lighting:** harsh cool light from a bare bulb and gray windows, blue-gray shadows · **Mood:** lonely, hollow · **Action:** lying still, eyes open

☐ Image made

Beat 28 02:15 · ~4.5s · The Protagonist

“Now you sleep next to a box labeled MISC in your own handwriting.”

IMAGE PROMPT

The protagonist curled on the floor mattress, a cardboard box labeled MISC in black marker beside him where a wife would be. The protagonist is a man in his mid-fifties with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair with gray streaks at the temples, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines and soft crow's feet, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows with a few gray hairs, light salt-and-pepper stubble, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a plain black hoodie, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: low side-angle shot at mattress level. Lighting: harsh cool light from a bare bulb and gray windows, blue-gray shadows. Mood: pathetic, quietly funny-sad.

Camera: low side-angle shot at mattress level · **Lighting:** harsh cool light from a bare bulb and gray windows, blue-gray shadows · **Mood:** pathetic, quietly funny-sad · **Action:** staring at the box

☐ Image made

Beat 29 02:20 · ~7.3s · The Protagonist

“You used to own two businesses. A flooring company with eleven employees and three vans with your name on the side.”

IMAGE PROMPT

Flashback-style memory panel: the protagonist proudly standing in front of a flooring warehouse with eleven smiling employees and three white vans with his name painted on the side. The protagonist is a man in his mid-fifties with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair with gray streaks at the temples, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines and soft crow's feet, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows with a few gray hairs, light salt-and-pepper stubble, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a plain black hoodie, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: wide group shot. Lighting: soft warm memory daylight, slightly faded. Mood: proud, lost past.

Camera: wide group shot · **Lighting:** soft warm memory daylight, slightly faded · **Mood:** proud, lost past · **Action:** arms crossed, almost smiling

☐ Image made

Beat 30 02:27 · ~5.6s · The Protagonist

“And a car wash out on Route 9 you bought the year your son was born.”

IMAGE PROMPT

Memory panel: a bright car wash on a highway with a ROUTE 9 sign, the protagonist younger, holding a newborn baby in a blanket in front of it. The protagonist is a man in his mid-fifties with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair with gray streaks at the temples, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines and soft crow's feet, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows with a few gray hairs, light salt-and-pepper stubble, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a plain black hoodie, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium-wide shot. Lighting: soft warm memory daylight, slightly faded. Mood: nostalgic, tender.

Camera: medium-wide shot · **Lighting:** soft warm memory daylight, slightly faded · **Mood:** nostalgic, tender · **Action:** holding the baby

☐ Image made

Beat 31 02:33 · ~5.6s · The Protagonist

“You thought the divorce would take the money. You didn't think it would take your mind.”

IMAGE PROMPT

Visual metaphor: the protagonist sitting at his desk while his own head is drawn like a cracked jar leaking puzzle pieces and calendar pages. The protagonist is a man in his mid-fifties with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair with gray streaks at the temples, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines and soft crow's feet, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows with a few gray hairs, light salt-and-pepper stubble, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a plain black hoodie, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium shot. Lighting: harsh cool light from a bare bulb and gray windows, blue-gray shadows. Mood: mental collapse.

Camera: medium shot · **Lighting:** harsh cool light from a bare bulb and gray windows, blue-gray shadows · **Mood:** mental collapse · **Action:** holding his head

☐ Image made

Beat 32 02:38 · ~4.2s · The Protagonist

“But it does. You forget a supplier meeting. Then a payroll date.”

IMAGE PROMPT

The protagonist at a cluttered office desk surrounded by sticky notes, a phone showing a missed call SUPPLIER MEETING and a calendar with PAYROLL circled and missed. The protagonist is a man in his mid-fifties with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair with gray streaks at the temples, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines and soft crow's feet, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows with a few gray hairs, light salt-and-pepper stubble, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a plain black hoodie, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium close-up. Lighting: harsh cool light from a bare bulb and gray windows, blue-gray shadows. Mood: overwhelmed, slipping.

Camera: medium close-up · **Lighting:** harsh cool light from a bare bulb and gray windows, blue-gray shadows · **Mood:** overwhelmed, slipping · **Action:** staring blankly at the calendar

☐ Image made

Beat 33 02:42 · ~6.6s · The Protagonist

“You sit in the truck outside the warehouse for forty minutes, engine off, unable to make yourself walk in.”

IMAGE PROMPT

The protagonist sitting motionless in his dented pickup in a warehouse parking lot, engine off, a dashboard clock reading 40 minutes passing, the warehouse door ahead. The protagonist is a man in his mid-fifties with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair with gray streaks at the temples, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines and soft crow's feet, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows with a few gray hairs, light salt-and-pepper stubble, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a plain black hoodie, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium shot through the windshield. Lighting: harsh cool light from a bare bulb and gray windows, blue-gray shadows. Mood: paralyzed, depressed.

Camera: medium shot through the windshield · **Lighting:** harsh cool light from a bare bulb and gray windows, blue-gray shadows · **Mood:** paralyzed, depressed · **Action:** gripping the wheel, not moving

☐ Image made

Beat 34 02:49 · ~5.2s · Luis, The Protagonist

“Your foreman, Luis, who's worked for you since he was nineteen, starts covering for you.”

IMAGE PROMPT

Inside the flooring warehouse, Luis answering a phone and handling a clipboard while the protagonist stands at the back staring at nothing. The protagonist is a man in his mid-fifties with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair with gray streaks at the temples, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines and soft crow's feet, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows with a few gray hairs, light salt-and-pepper stubble, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a plain black hoodie, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: Luis is a broad-shouldered Latino man in his early forties with a black buzz cut and thick mustache, wearing a gray work polo and dusty work pants. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium-wide shot, Luis in focus. Lighting: harsh cool light from a bare bulb and gray windows, blue-gray shadows. Mood: loyal, worried.

Camera: medium-wide shot, Luis in focus · **Lighting:** harsh cool light from a bare bulb and gray windows, blue-gray shadows · **Mood:** loyal, worried · **Action:** Luis covering for him

☐ Image made

Beat 35 02:54 · ~3.5s · Luis, The Protagonist

“Boss, he says one Friday. Go home. We got it.”

IMAGE PROMPT

Luis putting a heavy hand on the protagonist's shoulder at the warehouse door on a Friday evening, gently steering him out. The protagonist is a man in his mid-fifties with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair with gray streaks at the temples, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines and soft crow's feet, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows with a few gray hairs, light salt-and-pepper stubble, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a plain black hoodie, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: Luis is a broad-shouldered Latino man in his early forties with a black buzz cut and thick mustache, wearing a gray work polo and dusty work pants. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium two-shot. Lighting: harsh cool light from a bare bulb and gray windows, blue-gray shadows. Mood: kind, painful.

Camera: medium two-shot · **Lighting:** harsh cool light from a bare bulb and gray windows, blue-gray shadows · **Mood:** kind, painful · **Action:** Luis saying go home

☐ Image made

Beat 36 02:58 · ~2.1s · Insert / establishing

“They don't got it. Nobody does.”

IMAGE PROMPT

Visual metaphor: the flooring warehouse with stacks of unfinished orders piling up and toppling, vans parked and gathering dust. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: wide shot. Lighting: harsh cool light from a bare bulb and gray windows, blue-gray shadows. Mood: failing, inevitable.

Camera: wide shot · **Lighting:** harsh cool light from a bare bulb and gray windows, blue-gray shadows · **Mood:** failing, inevitable · **Action:** boxes tumbling

☐ Image made

Beat 37 03:00 · ~7.3s · The Protagonist, Luis

“The flooring company closes in August. You lay off eleven people at a folding table in the back of the warehouse.”

IMAGE PROMPT

A folding table in the back of the warehouse, the protagonist handing out final paychecks to a line of employees, a CLOSED sign leaning against the wall, AUGUST on the calendar. The protagonist is a man in his mid-fifties with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair with gray streaks at the temples, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines and soft crow's feet, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows with a few gray hairs, light salt-and-pepper stubble, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a plain black hoodie, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: Luis is a broad-shouldered Latino man in his early forties with a black buzz cut and thick mustache, wearing a gray work polo and dusty work pants. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: wide one-point perspective shot. Lighting: harsh cool light from a bare bulb and gray windows, blue-gray shadows. Mood: grim, shameful.

Camera: wide one-point perspective shot · **Lighting:** harsh cool light from a bare bulb and gray windows, blue-gray shadows · **Mood:** grim, shameful · **Action:** handing over envelopes

☐ Image made

Beat 38 03:07 · ~4.2s · Luis, The Protagonist

“Luis shakes your hand. He doesn't say anything. He doesn't have to.”

IMAGE PROMPT

Luis firmly shaking the protagonist's hand in the emptied warehouse, no words, both men looking at each other. The protagonist is a man in his mid-fifties with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair with gray streaks at the temples, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines and soft crow's feet, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows with a few gray hairs, light salt-and-pepper stubble, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a plain black hoodie, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: Luis is a broad-shouldered Latino man in his early forties with a black buzz cut and thick mustache, wearing a gray work polo and dusty work pants. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close two-shot on the handshake. Lighting: harsh cool light from a bare bulb and gray windows, blue-gray shadows. Mood: silent respect, grief.

Camera: close two-shot on the handshake · **Lighting:** harsh cool light from a bare bulb and gray windows, blue-gray shadows · **Mood:** silent respect, grief · **Action:** the handshake

☐ Image made

Beat 39 03:11 · ~7.7s · The Protagonist

“The car wash goes in October. The buyer pays $140,000. After the lender, the lawyers and the back taxes, you clear $9,000.”

IMAGE PROMPT

The car wash with a SOLD banner, a settlement sheet floating in the foreground: SALE $140,000 minus LENDER, LAWYERS, BACK TAXES, and at the bottom a tiny $9,000 circled. The protagonist is a man in his mid-fifties with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair with gray streaks at the temples, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines and soft crow's feet, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows with a few gray hairs, light salt-and-pepper stubble, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a plain black hoodie, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: split composition, document in foreground. Lighting: harsh cool light from a bare bulb and gray windows, blue-gray shadows. Mood: deflating.

Camera: split composition, document in foreground · **Lighting:** harsh cool light from a bare bulb and gray windows, blue-gray shadows · **Mood:** deflating · **Action:** numbers being subtracted

☐ Image made

Beat 40 03:19 · ~3.5s · Insert / establishing

“Not a crash. Just a slow leak. Like the faucet.”

IMAGE PROMPT

Close-up of the old bathroom faucet dripping, a single drop hanging, rhyming visually with the leaking money. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: extreme close-up insert. Lighting: harsh cool light from a bare bulb and gray windows, blue-gray shadows. Mood: quiet decay.

Camera: extreme close-up insert · **Lighting:** harsh cool light from a bare bulb and gray windows, blue-gray shadows · **Mood:** quiet decay · **Action:** a drop falling

☐ Image made

STAGE 3 · BEATS 41–48

New Chapter

Age 55 · Her cars, his canned soup

Beat 41 03:23 · ~5.2s · The Protagonist

“Meanwhile, Renée buys a car. You find out the way everyone finds out anything now.”

IMAGE PROMPT

The protagonist in his dim kitchen holding a can of soup, while in a glowing window-shaped inset Renée stands in a bright car showroom. The protagonist is a man in his mid-fifties with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair with gray streaks at the temples, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines and soft crow's feet, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows with a few gray hairs, light salt-and-pepper stubble, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a plain black hoodie, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: split composition, cold left and warm right. Lighting: flat cool fluorescent light, washed-out tones. Mood: contrast, unfair.

Camera: split composition, cold left and warm right · **Lighting:** flat cool fluorescent light, washed-out tones · **Mood:** contrast, unfair · **Action:** the protagonist looking at the glowing inset

☐ Image made

Beat 42 03:28 · ~5.6s · The Protagonist, Dana

“A photo. Your daughter's phone, face-up on the counter, at the one dinner she comes for.”

IMAGE PROMPT

At a small dinner table, Dana's phone lies face-up on the counter, the screen glowing with a social media post, the protagonist glancing at it while Dana looks away. The protagonist is a man in his mid-fifties with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair with gray streaks at the temples, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines and soft crow's feet, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows with a few gray hairs, light salt-and-pepper stubble, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a plain black hoodie, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: Dana is a twenty-six-year-old woman with dark curly hair in a low bun and a small silver nose stud, wearing a long mustard wool coat over a black turtleneck. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: high-angle shot over the counter. Lighting: flat cool fluorescent light, washed-out tones. Mood: awkward, painful.

Camera: high-angle shot over the counter · **Lighting:** flat cool fluorescent light, washed-out tones · **Mood:** awkward, painful · **Action:** the protagonist noticing the screen

☐ Image made

Beat 43 03:33 · ~5.9s · Renée

“Renée at a dealership, holding a giant red bow over a white SUV. $68,000. Caption: New chapter.”

IMAGE PROMPT

Close-up of a phone screen showing a social media post: Renée beaming with a giant red bow on a white SUV in a dealership, price tag $68,000, caption New chapter. Character notes: Renée is a slim, polished woman in her early fifties with a sleek honey-blonde bob, wearing a camel trench coat, gold jewelry and oversized sunglasses pushed up on her head. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: phone screen insert, centered. Lighting: bright warm showroom light inside the screen. Mood: flashy, smug.

Camera: phone screen insert, centered · **Lighting:** bright warm showroom light inside the screen · **Mood:** flashy, smug · **Action:** Renée posing with the bow

☐ Image made

Beat 44 03:39 · ~6.6s · Insert / establishing

“Three hundred and twelve people liked it. Some of them used to come to your Fourth of July barbecues.”

IMAGE PROMPT

Phone screen insert showing 312 likes and a scroll of small profile pictures, some labeled as old neighbors with a Fourth of July barbecue memory photo faintly overlaid. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close-up insert. Lighting: flat cool fluorescent light, washed-out tones. Mood: betrayed, public.

Camera: close-up insert · **Lighting:** flat cool fluorescent light, washed-out tones · **Mood:** betrayed, public · **Action:** likes ticking upward

☐ Image made

Beat 45 03:46 · ~4.2s · Renée

“Six weeks later, a second car. A convertible. Silver. Caption: Why not.”

IMAGE PROMPT

Renée driving a silver convertible with the top down, scarf flying, a phone post overlay reading Why not.. Character notes: Renée is a slim, polished woman in her early fifties with a sleek honey-blonde bob, wearing a camel trench coat, gold jewelry and oversized sunglasses pushed up on her head. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: dynamic medium shot from the passenger side. Lighting: bright warm afternoon sun. Mood: carefree, extravagant.

Camera: dynamic medium shot from the passenger side · **Lighting:** bright warm afternoon sun · **Mood:** carefree, extravagant · **Action:** Renée laughing at the wheel

☐ Image made

Beat 46 03:50 · ~7.0s · Renée, Renée's Sister

“She redoes the kitchen in the house that used to be yours. Takes a trip to Portugal with her sister.”

IMAGE PROMPT

Montage panel: Renée in a remodeled kitchen with marble counters in the old family house, and in a second panel Renée and her sister toasting on a sunny Portugal terrace. Character notes: Renée is a slim, polished woman in her early fifties with a sleek honey-blonde bob, wearing a camel trench coat, gold jewelry and oversized sunglasses pushed up on her head; Renée's sister is a woman in her late forties with big teased auburn hair, heavy makeup and a leopard-print blouse. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: two-panel split screen. Lighting: warm golden vacation light. Mood: indulgent, oblivious.

Camera: two-panel split screen · **Lighting:** warm golden vacation light · **Mood:** indulgent, oblivious · **Action:** clinking glasses

☐ Image made

Beat 47 03:57 · ~4.9s · Renée, The Protagonist

“Gets her teeth done. You're not angry. That's the strange part. You're just tired.”

IMAGE PROMPT

Renée flashing a new bright white smile in a dentist mirror, cut against the protagonist sitting alone on his porch steps looking tired, not angry. The protagonist is a man in his mid-fifties with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair with gray streaks at the temples, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines and soft crow's feet, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows with a few gray hairs, light salt-and-pepper stubble, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a plain black hoodie, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: Renée is a slim, polished woman in her early fifties with a sleek honey-blonde bob, wearing a camel trench coat, gold jewelry and oversized sunglasses pushed up on her head. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: split screen, warm left and cool right. Lighting: flat cool fluorescent light, washed-out tones. Mood: weary, numb.

Camera: split screen, warm left and cool right · **Lighting:** flat cool fluorescent light, washed-out tones · **Mood:** weary, numb · **Action:** the protagonist exhaling

☐ Image made

Beat 48 04:02 · ~6.6s · The Protagonist

“Tired the way you get after carrying something heavy so long you forget your arms are allowed to rest.”

IMAGE PROMPT

Visual metaphor: the protagonist trudging along carrying a huge heavy sack labeled THE DIVORCE on his back, his arms shaking, the road stretching ahead. The protagonist is a man in his mid-fifties with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair with gray streaks at the temples, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines and soft crow's feet, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows with a few gray hairs, light salt-and-pepper stubble, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a plain black hoodie, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: wide side-view shot. Lighting: flat cool fluorescent light, washed-out tones. Mood: exhausted.

Camera: wide side-view shot · **Lighting:** flat cool fluorescent light, washed-out tones · **Mood:** exhausted · **Action:** straining under the weight

☐ Image made

STAGE 4 · BEATS 49–56

Square One

Age 55 · The town decides

Beat 49 04:09 · ~2.4s · The Protagonist

“The town notices you, too. Just differently.”

IMAGE PROMPT

The protagonist walking through his small town, shop windows reflecting curious faces turning to watch him. The protagonist is a man in his mid-fifties with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair with gray streaks at the temples, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines and soft crow's feet, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows with a few gray hairs, light salt-and-pepper stubble, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a plain black hoodie, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium tracking shot. Lighting: flat cool overcast light, washed-out tones. Mood: observed, judged.

Camera: medium tracking shot · **Lighting:** flat cool overcast light, washed-out tones · **Mood:** observed, judged · **Action:** walking with hands in pockets

☐ Image made

Beat 50 04:11 · ~5.6s · The Protagonist, The Hardware Store Clerk

“At the hardware store, the guy who used to call you sir starts calling you buddy.”

IMAGE PROMPT

A hardware store checkout, the clerk leaning casually on the counter with a lazy grin calling out to the protagonist, a speech bubble reading Hey, buddy. The protagonist is a man in his mid-fifties with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair with gray streaks at the temples, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines and soft crow's feet, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows with a few gray hairs, light salt-and-pepper stubble, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a plain black hoodie, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: The hardware store clerk is a chubby man in his forties with a red beard and a backwards cap, wearing a rust-orange store apron. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium two-shot across the counter. Lighting: flat cool overcast light, washed-out tones. Mood: condescending.

Camera: medium two-shot across the counter · **Lighting:** flat cool overcast light, washed-out tones · **Mood:** condescending · **Action:** the clerk waving lazily

☐ Image made

Beat 51 04:17 · ~7.0s · The Protagonist, Greg

“Your old golf partner, Greg, sees you in the checkout line with a cart of canned soup and store-brand coffee,”

IMAGE PROMPT

Grocery checkout line, the protagonist's cart full of canned soup and store-brand coffee, Greg in a pastel golf polo at the next register noticing him. The protagonist is a man in his mid-fifties with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair with gray streaks at the temples, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines and soft crow's feet, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows with a few gray hairs, light salt-and-pepper stubble, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a plain black hoodie, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: Greg is a tanned man in his late fifties with perfect white hair and very white teeth, wearing a pastel golf polo. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium-wide shot, protagonist off-center left. Lighting: flat cool overcast light, washed-out tones. Mood: embarrassed.

Camera: medium-wide shot, protagonist off-center left · **Lighting:** flat cool overcast light, washed-out tones · **Mood:** embarrassed · **Action:** Greg noticing the cart

☐ Image made

Beat 52 04:24 · ~4.2s · Greg, The Protagonist

“and you watch him decide, in real time, not to come over.”

IMAGE PROMPT

Greg turning his body away, pretending to read a magazine rack, deliberately avoiding the protagonist in the background. The protagonist is a man in his mid-fifties with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair with gray streaks at the temples, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines and soft crow's feet, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows with a few gray hairs, light salt-and-pepper stubble, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a plain black hoodie, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: Greg is a tanned man in his late fifties with perfect white hair and very white teeth, wearing a pastel golf polo. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium shot, Greg in foreground. Lighting: flat cool overcast light, washed-out tones. Mood: cowardly, snubbing.

Camera: medium shot, Greg in foreground · **Lighting:** flat cool overcast light, washed-out tones · **Mood:** cowardly, snubbing · **Action:** Greg turning away

☐ Image made

Beat 53 04:28 · ~6.6s · The Church Woman, The Protagonist

“At church, a woman you barely know presses a hand on your arm. Starting over at fifty-five, she says.”

IMAGE PROMPT

Church lobby after service, a small elderly woman with a silver perm pressing her hand on the protagonist's arm with a syrupy pitying smile. The protagonist is a man in his mid-fifties with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair with gray streaks at the temples, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines and soft crow's feet, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows with a few gray hairs, light salt-and-pepper stubble, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a plain black hoodie, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: The church woman is a petite woman in her seventies with a silver perm and a pastel floral dress. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium close two-shot. Lighting: flat cool overcast light, washed-out tones. Mood: patronizing.

Camera: medium close two-shot · **Lighting:** flat cool overcast light, washed-out tones · **Mood:** patronizing · **Action:** patting his arm

☐ Image made

Beat 54 04:34 · ~5.2s · The Church Woman, The Protagonist

“You're so brave. Brave. That's the word people use when they've already decided you lost.”

IMAGE PROMPT

Close on the church woman's sugary face saying You're so brave, the word BRAVE floating above like a heavy stamp on the protagonist. The protagonist is a man in his mid-fifties with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair with gray streaks at the temples, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines and soft crow's feet, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows with a few gray hairs, light salt-and-pepper stubble, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a plain black hoodie, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: The church woman is a petite woman in her seventies with a silver perm and a pastel floral dress. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close-up with floating text. Lighting: flat cool overcast light, washed-out tones. Mood: pity, condescension.

Camera: close-up with floating text · **Lighting:** flat cool overcast light, washed-out tones · **Mood:** pity, condescension · **Action:** the word stamping down

☐ Image made

Beat 55 04:40 · ~5.9s · The Protagonist

“At a graduation party, somebody says it loud enough for you to hear. Back to square one.”

IMAGE PROMPT

A backyard graduation party with balloons, guests gossiping in a cluster, one loudly gesturing at the protagonist standing alone by the punch bowl. The protagonist is a man in his mid-fifties with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair with gray streaks at the temples, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines and soft crow's feet, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows with a few gray hairs, light salt-and-pepper stubble, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a plain black hoodie, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: wide shot, protagonist isolated on the right. Lighting: flat washed-out afternoon light. Mood: gossipy, cruel.

Camera: wide shot, protagonist isolated on the right · **Lighting:** flat washed-out afternoon light · **Mood:** gossipy, cruel · **Action:** guests laughing behind their hands

☐ Image made

Beat 56 04:46 · ~2.4s · The Protagonist

“Back to zero. You don't correct anyone.”

IMAGE PROMPT

Visual metaphor: the protagonist standing on a giant board-game square labeled START / 0, saying nothing. The protagonist is a man in his mid-fifties with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair with gray streaks at the temples, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines and soft crow's feet, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows with a few gray hairs, light salt-and-pepper stubble, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a plain black hoodie, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: high-angle symbolic shot. Lighting: flat cool overcast light, washed-out tones. Mood: resigned, silent.

Camera: high-angle symbolic shot · **Lighting:** flat cool overcast light, washed-out tones · **Mood:** resigned, silent · **Action:** standing quietly

☐ Image made

STAGE 5 · BEATS 57–68

The Children

Age 55 · The coat that stays on

Beat 57 04:48 · ~3.1s · The Protagonist

“The children are the part that actually breaks you.”

IMAGE PROMPT

The protagonist alone looking at a framed family photo of his two children when they were small, on a cheap shelf. The protagonist is a man in his mid-fifties with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair with gray streaks at the temples, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines and soft crow's feet, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows with a few gray hairs, light salt-and-pepper stubble, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a plain black hoodie, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close medium shot. Lighting: flat cool overcast daylight, washed-out tones. Mood: heartbreaking.

Camera: close medium shot · **Lighting:** flat cool overcast daylight, washed-out tones · **Mood:** heartbreaking · **Action:** holding the frame

☐ Image made

Beat 58 04:51 · ~5.9s · Dana

“Dana is twenty-six. She drives in from the city once a month, then once every two months.”

IMAGE PROMPT

Dana driving in from the city on a highway, a calendar overlay with visits crossed off from monthly to every two months. Character notes: Dana is a twenty-six-year-old woman with dark curly hair in a low bun and a small silver nose stud, wearing a long mustard wool coat over a black turtleneck. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium shot through the car window. Lighting: flat cool overcast daylight, washed-out tones. Mood: distance growing.

Camera: medium shot through the car window · **Lighting:** flat cool overcast daylight, washed-out tones · **Mood:** distance growing · **Action:** Dana gripping the wheel

☐ Image made

Beat 59 04:57 · ~6.6s · Dana, The Protagonist

“She walks into the house on Calloway Street, and you watch her eyes go to the porch, the stain,”

IMAGE PROMPT

Dana stepping into the old Calloway Street living room, her eyes moving over the sagging porch, the ceiling stain and the stove. The protagonist is a man in his mid-fifties with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair with gray streaks at the temples, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines and soft crow's feet, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows with a few gray hairs, light salt-and-pepper stubble, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a plain black hoodie, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: Dana is a twenty-six-year-old woman with dark curly hair in a low bun and a small silver nose stud, wearing a long mustard wool coat over a black turtleneck. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium-wide shot from behind the protagonist. Lighting: flat cool overcast daylight, washed-out tones. Mood: awkward, sad.

Camera: medium-wide shot from behind the protagonist · **Lighting:** flat cool overcast daylight, washed-out tones · **Mood:** awkward, sad · **Action:** Dana scanning the room

☐ Image made

Beat 60 05:04 · ~5.6s · Dana

“the one working burner. She tries not to let her face do anything. It does anyway.”

IMAGE PROMPT

Close-up on Dana's face trying to stay neutral but her eyebrows tightening in quiet pity and worry. Character notes: Dana is a twenty-six-year-old woman with dark curly hair in a low bun and a small silver nose stud, wearing a long mustard wool coat over a black turtleneck. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close-up. Lighting: flat cool overcast daylight, washed-out tones. Mood: pained, loving.

Camera: close-up · **Lighting:** flat cool overcast daylight, washed-out tones · **Mood:** pained, loving · **Action:** Dana holding back a frown

☐ Image made

Beat 61 05:09 · ~2.8s · Dana, The Protagonist

“Dad, she says. Are you okay? Like, actually?”

IMAGE PROMPT

Dana at the small kitchen table, leaning forward with concern, asking Are you okay? Like, actually?. The protagonist is a man in his mid-fifties with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair with gray streaks at the temples, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines and soft crow's feet, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows with a few gray hairs, light salt-and-pepper stubble, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a plain black hoodie, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: Dana is a twenty-six-year-old woman with dark curly hair in a low bun and a small silver nose stud, wearing a long mustard wool coat over a black turtleneck. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium two-shot across the table. Lighting: flat cool overcast daylight, washed-out tones. Mood: tender, uncomfortable.

Camera: medium two-shot across the table · **Lighting:** flat cool overcast daylight, washed-out tones · **Mood:** tender, uncomfortable · **Action:** Dana reaching toward his hand

☐ Image made

Beat 62 05:12 · ~5.9s · Dana, The Protagonist

“You say you're fine. She stays an hour and forty minutes. She never takes her coat off.”

IMAGE PROMPT

Dana sitting on the edge of a chair still wearing her buttoned mustard coat, car keys in hand, a wall clock showing 1 hour 40 minutes passed. The protagonist is a man in his mid-fifties with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair with gray streaks at the temples, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines and soft crow's feet, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows with a few gray hairs, light salt-and-pepper stubble, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a plain black hoodie, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: Dana is a twenty-six-year-old woman with dark curly hair in a low bun and a small silver nose stud, wearing a long mustard wool coat over a black turtleneck. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium-wide shot. Lighting: flat cool overcast daylight, washed-out tones. Mood: polite distance.

Camera: medium-wide shot · **Lighting:** flat cool overcast daylight, washed-out tones · **Mood:** polite distance · **Action:** Dana ready to leave

☐ Image made

Beat 63 05:18 · ~6.6s · Eli

“Eli is sixteen. Every other weekend is supposed to be yours. He comes twice. The third time, he texts.”

IMAGE PROMPT

Close-up of Eli's phone screen with a calendar showing every-other-weekend marked DAD, two days checked, then a text bubble: Got a thing. Sorry.. Character notes: Eli is a lanky sixteen-year-old boy with messy dark curly hair and earbuds around his neck, wearing a faded maroon hoodie. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: phone screen insert with Eli's thumb. Lighting: flat cool overcast daylight, washed-out tones. Mood: drifting away.

Camera: phone screen insert with Eli's thumb · **Lighting:** flat cool overcast daylight, washed-out tones · **Mood:** drifting away · **Action:** Eli typing

☐ Image made

Beat 64 05:25 · ~4.2s · The Protagonist

“Got a thing. Sorry. The fourth time, he doesn't text at all.”

IMAGE PROMPT

The protagonist sitting by the front window on a Saturday, phone in hand with no new messages, an unopened bag of chips for two on the table. The protagonist is a man in his mid-fifties with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair with gray streaks at the temples, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines and soft crow's feet, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows with a few gray hairs, light salt-and-pepper stubble, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a plain black hoodie, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium shot through the window. Lighting: flat cool overcast daylight, washed-out tones. Mood: abandoned.

Camera: medium shot through the window · **Lighting:** flat cool overcast daylight, washed-out tones · **Mood:** abandoned · **Action:** checking his phone

☐ Image made

Beat 65 05:29 · ~6.3s · Eli, Eli's Friend

“Later, you find out why. A friend dropped him off once and said, Bro, your dad lives here?”

IMAGE PROMPT

A cocky teenage friend leaning out of a small car's window at the curb of the run-down house, laughing, Eli in the passenger seat. Character notes: Eli is a lanky sixteen-year-old boy with messy dark curly hair and earbuds around his neck, wearing a faded maroon hoodie; Eli's friend is a cocky sixteen-year-old with bleached tips in his hair, wearing a varsity jacket. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium-wide shot from the sidewalk. Lighting: flat cool overcast daylight, washed-out tones. Mood: mocking.

Camera: medium-wide shot from the sidewalk · **Lighting:** flat cool overcast daylight, washed-out tones · **Mood:** mocking · **Action:** the friend pointing at the house

☐ Image made

Beat 66 05:35 · ~4.5s · Eli

“Like, here? Eli laughed it off. Then he stopped letting anyone drive him.”

IMAGE PROMPT

Eli forcing a laugh in the car, then a second panel of Eli walking home alone with his hood up, refusing rides. Character notes: Eli is a lanky sixteen-year-old boy with messy dark curly hair and earbuds around his neck, wearing a faded maroon hoodie. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: two-panel split. Lighting: flat cool overcast daylight, washed-out tones. Mood: ashamed.

Camera: two-panel split · **Lighting:** flat cool overcast daylight, washed-out tones · **Mood:** ashamed · **Action:** Eli shrugging it off

☐ Image made

Beat 67 05:40 · ~6.3s · Eli, The Protagonist

“Sixteen-year-olds don't hate you. They just don't want to be seen standing next to what happened to you.”

IMAGE PROMPT

Eli standing at a distance on the sidewalk, half-turned away from the protagonist and the shabby house, earbuds in. The protagonist is a man in his mid-fifties with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair with gray streaks at the temples, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines and soft crow's feet, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows with a few gray hairs, light salt-and-pepper stubble, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a plain black hoodie, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: Eli is a lanky sixteen-year-old boy with messy dark curly hair and earbuds around his neck, wearing a faded maroon hoodie. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: wide shot, the gap between them emphasized. Lighting: flat cool overcast daylight, washed-out tones. Mood: teenage shame.

Camera: wide shot, the gap between them emphasized · **Lighting:** flat cool overcast daylight, washed-out tones · **Mood:** teenage shame · **Action:** Eli looking at his phone

☐ Image made

Beat 68 05:46 · ~4.5s · The Protagonist

“You understand. That's the worst part. At sixteen, you'd have done the same.”

IMAGE PROMPT

The protagonist on the porch steps alone at dusk, a faint ghost image of his own sixteen-year-old self beside him doing the same thing. The protagonist is a man in his mid-fifties with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair with gray streaks at the temples, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines and soft crow's feet, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows with a few gray hairs, light salt-and-pepper stubble, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a plain black hoodie, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium shot. Lighting: flat cool overcast daylight, washed-out tones. Mood: understanding, painful.

Camera: medium shot · **Lighting:** flat cool overcast daylight, washed-out tones · **Mood:** understanding, painful · **Action:** staring at the street

☐ Image made

STAGE 6 · BEATS 69–77

The Bottom

Age 55 · November, no heat

Beat 69 05:51 · ~3.1s · The Protagonist

“The bottom isn't dramatic. It's a Thursday in November.”

IMAGE PROMPT

A gray Thursday in November outside the house on Calloway Street, bare trees, a calendar on the fridge showing NOVEMBER, frost on the windows. The protagonist is a man in his mid-fifties with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair with gray streaks at the temples, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines and soft crow's feet, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows with a few gray hairs, light salt-and-pepper stubble, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a black hoodie under a worn olive canvas coat, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: wide establishing shot. Lighting: harsh cold blue light, breath visible, deep blue-gray shadows. Mood: bleak, still.

Camera: wide establishing shot · **Lighting:** harsh cold blue light, breath visible, deep blue-gray shadows · **Mood:** bleak, still · **Action:** the protagonist barely visible in the window

☐ Image made

Beat 70 05:54 · ~5.2s · The Landlord

“The furnace makes a sound like a cough and quits. The landlord doesn't pick up.”

IMAGE PROMPT

An old basement furnace coughing a puff of black smoke and dying, and an inset of the landlord's phone ringing unanswered on a sofa beside him while he naps. Character notes: The landlord is a pot-bellied man in his sixties with a comb-over and gray mustache, wearing an open short-sleeve plaid shirt over a stained undershirt. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: split composition. Lighting: harsh cold blue light, breath visible, deep blue-gray shadows. Mood: neglect, cold.

Camera: split composition · **Lighting:** harsh cold blue light, breath visible, deep blue-gray shadows · **Mood:** neglect, cold · **Action:** the furnace sputtering out

☐ Image made

Beat 71 05:59 · ~1.4s · Insert / establishing

“It's thirty-four degrees outside.”

IMAGE PROMPT

Close-up of an outdoor thermometer on the porch post reading 34°F, frost creeping on the glass. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: extreme close-up insert. Lighting: harsh cold blue light, breath visible, deep blue-gray shadows. Mood: freezing.

Camera: extreme close-up insert · **Lighting:** harsh cold blue light, breath visible, deep blue-gray shadows · **Mood:** freezing · **Action:** the needle dropping

☐ Image made

Beat 72 06:00 · ~7.3s · The Protagonist

“You sit at the kitchen table in your coat, eating crackers out of the sleeve, and you open your banking app.”

IMAGE PROMPT

The protagonist at the kitchen table in his coat, breath visible, eating crackers from the sleeve, opening a banking app on a cracked phone. The protagonist is a man in his mid-fifties with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair with gray streaks at the temples, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines and soft crow's feet, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows with a few gray hairs, light salt-and-pepper stubble, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a black hoodie under a worn olive canvas coat, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium shot. Lighting: harsh cold blue light, breath visible, deep blue-gray shadows. Mood: rock bottom.

Camera: medium shot · **Lighting:** harsh cold blue light, breath visible, deep blue-gray shadows · **Mood:** rock bottom · **Action:** holding the phone

☐ Image made

Beat 73 06:08 · ~2.4s · Insert / establishing

“$2,316. Rent is due in nine days.”

IMAGE PROMPT

Close-up of the cracked phone screen showing a banking app: BALANCE $2,316 and a reminder notification RENT DUE IN 9 DAYS. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: phone screen insert. Lighting: harsh cold blue light, breath visible, deep blue-gray shadows. Mood: panic, cold.

Camera: phone screen insert · **Lighting:** harsh cold blue light, breath visible, deep blue-gray shadows · **Mood:** panic, cold · **Action:** the screen glowing

☐ Image made

Beat 74 06:10 · ~4.5s · The Protagonist

“You look up. The stain on the ceiling looks bigger. Maybe it is.”

IMAGE PROMPT

The protagonist looking up from the kitchen into the bedroom ceiling, the hand-shaped stain drawn noticeably larger than before. The protagonist is a man in his mid-fifties with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair with gray streaks at the temples, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines and soft crow's feet, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows with a few gray hairs, light salt-and-pepper stubble, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a black hoodie under a worn olive canvas coat, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: low-angle shot. Lighting: harsh cold blue light, breath visible, deep blue-gray shadows. Mood: creeping dread.

Camera: low-angle shot · **Lighting:** harsh cold blue light, breath visible, deep blue-gray shadows · **Mood:** creeping dread · **Action:** looking up

☐ Image made

Beat 75 06:15 · ~5.6s · The Protagonist

“And for the first time in a long time, you let yourself think about the envelope.”

IMAGE PROMPT

The protagonist's eyes in the dark, and a faint glowing outline of a cream envelope reflected in his glasses. The protagonist is a man in his mid-fifties with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair with gray streaks at the temples, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines and soft crow's feet, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows with a few gray hairs, light salt-and-pepper stubble, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a black hoodie under a worn olive canvas coat, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: extreme close-up. Lighting: harsh cold blue light, breath visible, deep blue-gray shadows. Mood: awakening thought.

Camera: extreme close-up · **Lighting:** harsh cold blue light, breath visible, deep blue-gray shadows · **Mood:** awakening thought · **Action:** his eyes narrowing

☐ Image made

Beat 76 06:20 · ~3.1s · The Protagonist

“And the question you'll keep asking yourself for months.”

IMAGE PROMPT

The protagonist staring at his reflection in the dark kitchen window, a faint question mark fogged on the glass. The protagonist is a man in his mid-fifties with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair with gray streaks at the temples, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines and soft crow's feet, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows with a few gray hairs, light salt-and-pepper stubble, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a black hoodie under a worn olive canvas coat, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium close-up. Lighting: harsh cold blue light, breath visible, deep blue-gray shadows. Mood: haunted.

Camera: medium close-up · **Lighting:** harsh cold blue light, breath visible, deep blue-gray shadows · **Mood:** haunted · **Action:** wiping the fog

☐ Image made

Beat 77 06:23 · ~2.1s · The Protagonist

“Why didn't you ever tell her?”

IMAGE PROMPT

The protagonist holding an old photo of Renée from their wedding day, the words WHY DIDN'T YOU TELL HER? faint in the shadows around him. The protagonist is a man in his mid-fifties with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair with gray streaks at the temples, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines and soft crow's feet, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows with a few gray hairs, light salt-and-pepper stubble, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a black hoodie under a worn olive canvas coat, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close-up. Lighting: harsh cold blue light, breath visible, deep blue-gray shadows. Mood: guilt, mystery.

Camera: close-up · **Lighting:** harsh cold blue light, breath visible, deep blue-gray shadows · **Mood:** guilt, mystery · **Action:** staring at the photo

☐ Image made

STAGE 7 · BEATS 78–91

Walter's Envelope

Flashback · Age 31

Beat 78 06:25 · ~6.6s · Walter

“You were thirty-one the year your grandfather died. Walter. Retired machinist. Wore the same brown cardigan for twenty years.”

IMAGE PROMPT

Flashback: Walter in his worn brown cardigan standing in a cluttered machinist's garage full of tools, a calendar on the wall reading 2001. Character notes: Walter is a frail man in his late eighties with thin white hair combed back, deep wrinkles and large knuckly hands, wearing a worn brown cardigan. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium-wide shot. Lighting: desaturated cold flashback light, pale hospital-window glow. Mood: humble, nostalgic.

Camera: medium-wide shot · **Lighting:** desaturated cold flashback light, pale hospital-window glow · **Mood:** humble, nostalgic · **Action:** wiping his hands on a rag

☐ Image made

Beat 79 06:32 · ~2.8s · Walter

“Drove a Buick until the floor rusted through.”

IMAGE PROMPT

Flashback: Walter driving an old rusted Buick, a hole in the floorboard showing the road beneath. Character notes: Walter is a frail man in his late eighties with thin white hair combed back, deep wrinkles and large knuckly hands, wearing a worn brown cardigan. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: side medium shot. Lighting: desaturated cold flashback light, pale hospital-window glow. Mood: frugal, endearing.

Camera: side medium shot · **Lighting:** desaturated cold flashback light, pale hospital-window glow · **Mood:** frugal, endearing · **Action:** gripping the wheel

☐ Image made

Beat 80 06:35 · ~5.2s · Walter

“Everyone in the family assumed he had just enough to pay for his own funeral.”

IMAGE PROMPT

Flashback family gathering: relatives whispering and rolling their eyes at Walter in his cardigan, a speech bubble reading barely enough for a funeral. Character notes: Walter is a frail man in his late eighties with thin white hair combed back, deep wrinkles and large knuckly hands, wearing a worn brown cardigan. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: wide group shot. Lighting: desaturated cold flashback light, pale hospital-window glow. Mood: underestimated.

Camera: wide group shot · **Lighting:** desaturated cold flashback light, pale hospital-window glow · **Mood:** underestimated · **Action:** Walter calmly sipping coffee

☐ Image made

Beat 81 06:40 · ~4.5s · The Protagonist (younger), Walter

“Two weeks before he passed, he called you to his bedside. Only you.”

IMAGE PROMPT

Flashback: a small hospital room, Walter frail in bed waving the protagonist at age thirty-one over to his bedside, no one else in the room. The protagonist at thirty-one is a young man of thirty-one with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair with no gray, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, clean-shaven pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a plain black crewneck sweater, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: Walter is a frail man in his late eighties with thin white hair combed back, deep wrinkles and large knuckly hands, wearing a worn brown cardigan. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium-wide shot. Lighting: desaturated cold flashback light, pale hospital-window glow. Mood: intimate, solemn.

Camera: medium-wide shot · **Lighting:** desaturated cold flashback light, pale hospital-window glow · **Mood:** intimate, solemn · **Action:** Walter beckoning

☐ Image made

Beat 82 06:45 · ~5.2s · The Protagonist (younger), Walter

“He pressed an envelope into your palm with a lawyer's name on it. Thomas Hollis.”

IMAGE PROMPT

Close-up of Walter pressing a cream envelope into the young protagonist's palm, the name THOMAS HOLLIS, ATTORNEY written on it. The protagonist at thirty-one is a young man of thirty-one with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair with no gray, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, clean-shaven pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a plain black crewneck sweater, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: Walter is a frail man in his late eighties with thin white hair combed back, deep wrinkles and large knuckly hands, wearing a worn brown cardigan. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close-up insert on the hands. Lighting: desaturated cold flashback light, pale hospital-window glow. Mood: sacred, secret.

Camera: close-up insert on the hands · **Lighting:** desaturated cold flashback light, pale hospital-window glow · **Mood:** sacred, secret · **Action:** the envelope changing hands

☐ Image made

Beat 83 06:50 · ~3.1s · The Protagonist (younger), Walter

“He held your wrist. His grip was still strong.”

IMAGE PROMPT

Walter's knuckly hand gripping the young protagonist's wrist firmly from the hospital bed. The protagonist at thirty-one is a young man of thirty-one with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair with no gray, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, clean-shaven pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a plain black crewneck sweater, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: Walter is a frail man in his late eighties with thin white hair combed back, deep wrinkles and large knuckly hands, wearing a worn brown cardigan. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close-up on the hands. Lighting: desaturated cold flashback light, pale hospital-window glow. Mood: intense.

Camera: close-up on the hands · **Lighting:** desaturated cold flashback light, pale hospital-window glow · **Mood:** intense · **Action:** holding tight

☐ Image made

Beat 84 06:53 · ~5.9s · Walter, The Protagonist (younger)

“It stays in my name, he said. Not yours. Mine. Until you're fifty-six. You don't touch it.”

IMAGE PROMPT

Walter staring hard into the young protagonist's eyes, a faint number 56 glowing in the air between them. The protagonist at thirty-one is a young man of thirty-one with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair with no gray, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, clean-shaven pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a plain black crewneck sweater, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: Walter is a frail man in his late eighties with thin white hair combed back, deep wrinkles and large knuckly hands, wearing a worn brown cardigan. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium close two-shot. Lighting: desaturated cold flashback light, pale hospital-window glow. Mood: serious, binding.

Camera: medium close two-shot · **Lighting:** desaturated cold flashback light, pale hospital-window glow · **Mood:** serious, binding · **Action:** Walter speaking firmly

☐ Image made

Beat 85 06:59 · ~4.5s · Walter, The Protagonist (younger)

“You don't tell anyone. Not your wife. Not your friends. Not your kids.”

IMAGE PROMPT

Walter raising a finger, small faded icons floating above: a wedding ring, two friends and two children, each crossed out. The protagonist at thirty-one is a young man of thirty-one with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair with no gray, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, clean-shaven pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a plain black crewneck sweater, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: Walter is a frail man in his late eighties with thin white hair combed back, deep wrinkles and large knuckly hands, wearing a worn brown cardigan. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium two-shot. Lighting: desaturated cold flashback light, pale hospital-window glow. Mood: secretive.

Camera: medium two-shot · **Lighting:** desaturated cold flashback light, pale hospital-window glow · **Mood:** secretive · **Action:** Walter counting off on his fingers

☐ Image made

Beat 86 07:04 · ~7.3s · Walter, The Protagonist (younger)

“Why? you asked. He looked at you for a long time. Because money people know about stops being yours, he said.”

IMAGE PROMPT

Walter's tired, wise face looking at the protagonist a long moment, a cluster of opinion speech bubbles drawn swarming around a small bag of money. The protagonist at thirty-one is a young man of thirty-one with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair with no gray, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, clean-shaven pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a plain black crewneck sweater, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: Walter is a frail man in his late eighties with thin white hair combed back, deep wrinkles and large knuckly hands, wearing a worn brown cardigan. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium close-up on Walter. Lighting: desaturated cold flashback light, pale hospital-window glow. Mood: wisdom.

Camera: medium close-up on Walter · **Lighting:** desaturated cold flashback light, pale hospital-window glow · **Mood:** wisdom · **Action:** Walter speaking softly

☐ Image made

Beat 87 07:11 · ~3.1s · Walter, The Protagonist (younger)

“It becomes everybody's opinion. Then he closed his eyes.”

IMAGE PROMPT

Walter closing his eyes peacefully, the young protagonist holding his hand at the bedside. The protagonist at thirty-one is a young man of thirty-one with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair with no gray, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, clean-shaven pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a plain black crewneck sweater, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: Walter is a frail man in his late eighties with thin white hair combed back, deep wrinkles and large knuckly hands, wearing a worn brown cardigan. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium shot. Lighting: desaturated cold flashback light, pale hospital-window glow. Mood: grief, quiet.

Camera: medium shot · **Lighting:** desaturated cold flashback light, pale hospital-window glow · **Mood:** grief, quiet · **Action:** the protagonist bowing his head

☐ Image made

Beat 88 07:14 · ~4.2s · The Protagonist (younger)

“You never told Renée. Not because you planned for this. You didn't.”

IMAGE PROMPT

The young protagonist at home putting the envelope away in a drawer while young Renée laughs in the next room, unaware. The protagonist at thirty-one is a young man of thirty-one with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair with no gray, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, clean-shaven pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a plain black crewneck sweater, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium-wide shot. Lighting: desaturated cold flashback light, pale hospital-window glow. Mood: the choice.

Camera: medium-wide shot · **Lighting:** desaturated cold flashback light, pale hospital-window glow · **Mood:** the choice · **Action:** sliding the drawer closed

☐ Image made

Beat 89 07:18 · ~6.3s · The Protagonist (younger)

“You made a promise to a dying man in a brown cardigan, and then twenty-four years went by,”

IMAGE PROMPT

A time-lapse panel: the same drawer, a calendar flipping from 2001 through many years, the envelope gathering dust. The protagonist at thirty-one is a young man of thirty-one with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair with no gray, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, clean-shaven pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a plain black crewneck sweater, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: wide symbolic shot. Lighting: desaturated cold flashback light, pale hospital-window glow. Mood: time passing.

Camera: wide symbolic shot · **Lighting:** desaturated cold flashback light, pale hospital-window glow · **Mood:** time passing · **Action:** pages flying

☐ Image made

Beat 90 07:24 · ~3.5s · The Protagonist (younger)

“and the promise turned into furniture. Something you stopped seeing.”

IMAGE PROMPT

Visual metaphor: the envelope slowly turning into a piece of furniture in the corner of a family living room, nobody noticing. The protagonist at thirty-one is a young man of thirty-one with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair with no gray, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, clean-shaven pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a plain black crewneck sweater, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium symbolic shot. Lighting: desaturated cold flashback light, pale hospital-window glow. Mood: forgotten, normal.

Camera: medium symbolic shot · **Lighting:** desaturated cold flashback light, pale hospital-window glow · **Mood:** forgotten, normal · **Action:** family life moving around it

☐ Image made

Beat 91 07:28 · ~5.2s · The Protagonist

“Sitting in that cold kitchen, you do the math. Your birthday is in seven weeks.”

IMAGE PROMPT

Back in the cold present: the protagonist at the freezing kitchen table counting on his fingers, a calendar showing his birthday circled seven weeks away. The protagonist is a man in his mid-fifties with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair with gray streaks at the temples, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines and soft crow's feet, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows with a few gray hairs, light salt-and-pepper stubble, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a black hoodie under a worn olive canvas coat, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium shot. Lighting: harsh cold blue light, breath visible. Mood: realization.

Camera: medium shot · **Lighting:** harsh cold blue light, breath visible · **Mood:** realization · **Action:** counting

☐ Image made

STAGE 8 · BEATS 92–104

The Gold Pen

Age 56 · $1,046,000

Beat 92 07:33 · ~2.1s · The Protagonist

“On January 14th, you turn fifty-six.”

IMAGE PROMPT

The protagonist alone at the kitchen table with a single candle in a supermarket cupcake, a calendar reading JANUARY 14. The protagonist is a man in his mid-fifties with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair with gray streaks at the temples, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines and soft crow's feet, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows with a few gray hairs, light salt-and-pepper stubble, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a black quarter-zip pullover, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium close-up. Lighting: soft warm daylight through an old office window. Mood: quiet milestone.

Camera: medium close-up · **Lighting:** soft warm daylight through an old office window · **Mood:** quiet milestone · **Action:** looking at the flame

☐ Image made

Beat 93 07:35 · ~5.9s · The Protagonist, Thomas Hollis

“On January 16th, you sit in an office above a bakery downtown. Thomas Hollis is eighty-one now.”

IMAGE PROMPT

A small old law office above a bakery, a bakery sign visible through the window below, the protagonist sitting across from an ancient lawyer, Thomas Hollis, behind a cluttered desk. The protagonist is a man in his mid-fifties with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair with gray streaks at the temples, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines and soft crow's feet, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows with a few gray hairs, light salt-and-pepper stubble, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a black quarter-zip pullover, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: Thomas Hollis is a stooped eighty-one-year-old lawyer with a bald spotted head, round wire glasses and trembling hands, wearing a gray tweed three-piece suit. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: wide one-point perspective interior. Lighting: soft warm daylight through an old office window. Mood: anticipation.

Camera: wide one-point perspective interior · **Lighting:** soft warm daylight through an old office window · **Mood:** anticipation · **Action:** sitting down

☐ Image made

Beat 94 07:41 · ~4.5s · Martin Hollis, The Protagonist, Thomas Hollis

“His son, Martin, handles the paperwork. He slides a folder across the desk.”

IMAGE PROMPT

Martin Hollis sliding a thick manila trust folder across the desk toward the protagonist, Thomas watching quietly. The protagonist is a man in his mid-fifties with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair with gray streaks at the temples, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines and soft crow's feet, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows with a few gray hairs, light salt-and-pepper stubble, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a black quarter-zip pullover, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: Martin Hollis is a neat man in his early fifties with short graying hair and a trimmed beard, wearing a navy suit and light-blue shirt; Thomas Hollis is a stooped eighty-one-year-old lawyer with a bald spotted head, round wire glasses and trembling hands, wearing a gray tweed three-piece suit. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: over-the-shoulder shot. Lighting: soft warm daylight through an old office window. Mood: serious.

Camera: over-the-shoulder shot · **Lighting:** soft warm daylight through an old office window · **Mood:** serious · **Action:** the folder sliding

☐ Image made

Beat 95 07:46 · ~5.2s · Martin Hollis

“Your grandfather placed $310,000 into this trust in 1999, Martin says. Managed conservatively. Index funds.”

IMAGE PROMPT

Martin reading from a document, an insert showing an old trust deposit slip: $310,000 — 1999. Character notes: Martin Hollis is a neat man in his early fifties with short graying hair and a trimmed beard, wearing a navy suit and light-blue shirt. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium shot with document insert. Lighting: soft warm daylight through an old office window. Mood: revealing.

Camera: medium shot with document insert · **Lighting:** soft warm daylight through an old office window · **Mood:** revealing · **Action:** Martin pointing at the figure

☐ Image made

Beat 96 07:51 · ~3.5s · Martin Hollis, The Protagonist

“Treasury bonds. Untouched. He turns the last page toward you.”

IMAGE PROMPT

Martin turning the last page around, the protagonist leaning in to look. The protagonist is a man in his mid-fifties with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair with gray streaks at the temples, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines and soft crow's feet, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows with a few gray hairs, light salt-and-pepper stubble, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a black quarter-zip pullover, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: Martin Hollis is a neat man in his early fifties with short graying hair and a trimmed beard, wearing a navy suit and light-blue shirt. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close two-shot over the desk. Lighting: soft warm daylight through an old office window. Mood: suspense.

Camera: close two-shot over the desk · **Lighting:** soft warm daylight through an old office window · **Mood:** suspense · **Action:** the page turning

☐ Image made

Beat 97 07:54 · ~4.2s · The Protagonist

“Current value. $1,046,000. You read it three times. The number doesn't change.”

IMAGE PROMPT

Extreme close-up of the trust statement: CURRENT VALUE $1,046,000 in bold, the protagonist's glasses reflecting the number. The protagonist is a man in his mid-fifties with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair with gray streaks at the temples, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines and soft crow's feet, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows with a few gray hairs, light salt-and-pepper stubble, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a black quarter-zip pullover, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: extreme close-up insert. Lighting: soft warm daylight through an old office window. Mood: stunned.

Camera: extreme close-up insert · **Lighting:** soft warm daylight through an old office window · **Mood:** stunned · **Action:** reading it again and again

☐ Image made

Beat 98 07:59 · ~6.3s · Martin Hollis, The Protagonist

“It was held in his name the entire time, Martin says. It was never part of your marriage.”

IMAGE PROMPT

Martin explaining calmly with a hand on the folder, a small diagram on the desk showing the trust held separately in Walter's name, away from the marriage. The protagonist is a man in his mid-fifties with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair with gray streaks at the temples, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines and soft crow's feet, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows with a few gray hairs, light salt-and-pepper stubble, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a black quarter-zip pullover, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: Martin Hollis is a neat man in his early fifties with short graying hair and a trimmed beard, wearing a navy suit and light-blue shirt. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium two-shot. Lighting: soft warm daylight through an old office window. Mood: clarity, relief.

Camera: medium two-shot · **Lighting:** soft warm daylight through an old office window · **Mood:** clarity, relief · **Action:** Martin gesturing

☐ Image made

Beat 99 08:05 · ~4.9s · Martin Hollis, The Protagonist

“Never part of your settlement. Today, it becomes yours. You just have to sign.”

IMAGE PROMPT

Martin offering a document with a SIGN HERE tab, the protagonist looking at it. The protagonist is a man in his mid-fifties with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair with gray streaks at the temples, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines and soft crow's feet, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows with a few gray hairs, light salt-and-pepper stubble, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a black quarter-zip pullover, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: Martin Hollis is a neat man in his early fifties with short graying hair and a trimmed beard, wearing a navy suit and light-blue shirt. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium shot. Lighting: soft warm daylight through an old office window. Mood: decisive moment.

Camera: medium shot · **Lighting:** soft warm daylight through an old office window · **Mood:** decisive moment · **Action:** Martin waiting

☐ Image made

Beat 100 08:10 · ~2.8s · Martin Hollis, The Protagonist

“He offers you a pen. Heavy. Black. Expensive.”

IMAGE PROMPT

Martin holding out a sleek heavy black luxury pen to the protagonist. The protagonist is a man in his mid-fifties with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair with gray streaks at the temples, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines and soft crow's feet, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows with a few gray hairs, light salt-and-pepper stubble, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a black quarter-zip pullover, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: Martin Hollis is a neat man in his early fifties with short graying hair and a trimmed beard, wearing a navy suit and light-blue shirt. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close-up on the pen. Lighting: soft warm daylight through an old office window. Mood: formal.

Camera: close-up on the pen · **Lighting:** soft warm daylight through an old office window · **Mood:** formal · **Action:** offering the pen

☐ Image made

Beat 101 08:13 · ~6.3s · Thomas Hollis, Martin Hollis, The Protagonist

“Then old Thomas reaches over, with a hand that shakes worse than yours ever did, and stops him.”

IMAGE PROMPT

Old Thomas Hollis reaching across with a trembling spotted hand to stop Martin's pen. The protagonist is a man in his mid-fifties with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair with gray streaks at the temples, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines and soft crow's feet, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows with a few gray hairs, light salt-and-pepper stubble, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a black quarter-zip pullover, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: Thomas Hollis is a stooped eighty-one-year-old lawyer with a bald spotted head, round wire glasses and trembling hands, wearing a gray tweed three-piece suit; Martin Hollis is a neat man in his early fifties with short graying hair and a trimmed beard, wearing a navy suit and light-blue shirt. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium three-shot. Lighting: soft warm daylight through an old office window. Mood: meaningful.

Camera: medium three-shot · **Lighting:** soft warm daylight through an old office window · **Mood:** meaningful · **Action:** Thomas intervening

☐ Image made

Beat 102 08:19 · ~3.8s · Thomas Hollis, The Protagonist

“He gives you a different pen. Worn gold. A little scratched.”

IMAGE PROMPT

Close-up of Thomas placing a worn, scratched gold fountain pen into the protagonist's palm. The protagonist is a man in his mid-fifties with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair with gray streaks at the temples, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines and soft crow's feet, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows with a few gray hairs, light salt-and-pepper stubble, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a black quarter-zip pullover, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: Thomas Hollis is a stooped eighty-one-year-old lawyer with a bald spotted head, round wire glasses and trembling hands, wearing a gray tweed three-piece suit. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: extreme close-up insert on the hands. Lighting: soft warm daylight through an old office window. Mood: sacred, emotional.

Camera: extreme close-up insert on the hands · **Lighting:** soft warm daylight through an old office window · **Mood:** sacred, emotional · **Action:** the pen being passed

☐ Image made

Beat 103 08:23 · ~5.9s · Thomas Hollis, The Protagonist

“This was Walter's, he says. He left it with me. Said you'd need it on the day.”

IMAGE PROMPT

Thomas smiling faintly, a ghostly translucent image of Walter in his brown cardigan standing behind him. The protagonist is a man in his mid-fifties with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair with gray streaks at the temples, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines and soft crow's feet, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows with a few gray hairs, light salt-and-pepper stubble, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a black quarter-zip pullover, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: Thomas Hollis is a stooped eighty-one-year-old lawyer with a bald spotted head, round wire glasses and trembling hands, wearing a gray tweed three-piece suit. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium shot. Lighting: soft warm daylight through an old office window. Mood: emotional, nostalgic.

Camera: medium shot · **Lighting:** soft warm daylight through an old office window · **Mood:** emotional, nostalgic · **Action:** Thomas speaking

☐ Image made

Beat 104 08:29 · ~4.9s · The Protagonist

“You sign. Your hand doesn't shake this time either. But for a different reason.”

IMAGE PROMPT

The protagonist signing the trust document with Walter's gold pen, hand steady, a single tear behind his glasses. The protagonist is a man in his mid-fifties with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair with gray streaks at the temples, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines and soft crow's feet, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows with a few gray hairs, light salt-and-pepper stubble, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a black quarter-zip pullover, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close-up on the signature. Lighting: soft warm daylight through an old office window. Mood: closure, quiet power.

Camera: close-up on the signature · **Lighting:** soft warm daylight through an old office window · **Mood:** closure, quiet power · **Action:** signing

☐ Image made

Sir Again

Age 56 · The house, the coupe, the kids

Beat 105 08:34 · ~3.1s · The Protagonist

“You don't buy a mansion. You don't post anything.”

IMAGE PROMPT

The protagonist walking past a flashy mansion billboard and a phone showing social media without posting anything. The protagonist is a man in his mid-fifties with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair with gray streaks at the temples, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines and soft crow's feet, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows with a few gray hairs, light salt-and-pepper stubble, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a black quarter-zip pullover, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium tracking shot. Lighting: warm natural light with amber accents. Mood: restraint.

Camera: medium tracking shot · **Lighting:** warm natural light with amber accents · **Mood:** restraint · **Action:** putting the phone away

☐ Image made

Beat 106 08:37 · ~5.2s · The Protagonist, The Landlord

“The first thing you buy is the house on Calloway Street. The landlord wants out.”

IMAGE PROMPT

The protagonist on the Calloway Street porch with the landlord, a FOR SALE sign being taken down. The protagonist is a man in his mid-fifties with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair with gray streaks at the temples, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines and soft crow's feet, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows with a few gray hairs, light salt-and-pepper stubble, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a black quarter-zip pullover, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: The landlord is a pot-bellied man in his sixties with a comb-over and gray mustache, wearing an open short-sleeve plaid shirt over a stained undershirt. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium-wide two-shot. Lighting: warm natural light with amber accents. Mood: quiet win.

Camera: medium-wide two-shot · **Lighting:** warm natural light with amber accents · **Mood:** quiet win · **Action:** shaking hands

☐ Image made

Beat 107 08:42 · ~3.1s · The Protagonist, The Landlord

“$189,000. Cash. He looks at you like he misheard.”

IMAGE PROMPT

The landlord's jaw dropping, holding a cashier's check reading $189,000. The protagonist is a man in his mid-fifties with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair with gray streaks at the temples, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines and soft crow's feet, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows with a few gray hairs, light salt-and-pepper stubble, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a black quarter-zip pullover, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: The landlord is a pot-bellied man in his sixties with a comb-over and gray mustache, wearing an open short-sleeve plaid shirt over a stained undershirt. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium close-up on the landlord. Lighting: warm natural light with amber accents. Mood: surprise.

Camera: medium close-up on the landlord · **Lighting:** warm natural light with amber accents · **Mood:** surprise · **Action:** the landlord staring at the check

☐ Image made

Beat 108 08:45 · ~5.6s · The Protagonist

“Then a new furnace. $4,800. Installed the next morning. Then you fix the porch. The faucet.”

IMAGE PROMPT

Repair montage: a new furnace with a receipt $4,800, a repaired porch, a new faucet. The protagonist is a man in his mid-fifties with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair with gray streaks at the temples, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines and soft crow's feet, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows with a few gray hairs, light salt-and-pepper stubble, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a black quarter-zip pullover, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: three-panel split screen. Lighting: warm natural light with amber accents. Mood: renewal.

Camera: three-panel split screen · **Lighting:** warm natural light with amber accents · **Mood:** renewal · **Action:** the protagonist inspecting the work

☐ Image made

Beat 109 08:51 · ~4.5s · The Protagonist

“The burner. You leave the stain on the ceiling. You're not sure why.”

IMAGE PROMPT

The protagonist in the bedroom holding a paint roller, looking up at the hand-shaped stain and deciding not to paint it yet. The protagonist is a man in his mid-fifties with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair with gray streaks at the temples, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines and soft crow's feet, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows with a few gray hairs, light salt-and-pepper stubble, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a black quarter-zip pullover, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: low-angle shot. Lighting: warm natural light with amber accents. Mood: reflective.

Camera: low-angle shot · **Lighting:** warm natural light with amber accents · **Mood:** reflective · **Action:** lowering the roller

☐ Image made

Beat 110 08:55 · ~6.3s · The Protagonist

“In March, you buy a truck. Black. New. Then, in May, something you've wanted since you were nineteen.”

IMAGE PROMPT

The protagonist in a car dealership standing beside a brand new black pickup truck, then a calendar flipping to May. The protagonist is a man in his mid-fifties with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair with gray streaks at the temples, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines and soft crow's feet, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows with a few gray hairs, light salt-and-pepper stubble, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a black quarter-zip pullover, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium-wide shot. Lighting: warm natural light with amber accents. Mood: growing confidence.

Camera: medium-wide shot · **Lighting:** warm natural light with amber accents · **Mood:** growing confidence · **Action:** holding the keys

☐ Image made

Beat 111 09:01 · ~5.6s · The Protagonist

“A dark green 1967 coupe, restored, chrome so clean you can see your face in it.”

IMAGE PROMPT

A gleaming dark green 1967 coupe, the protagonist's reflection visible in the shiny chrome bumper. The protagonist is a man in his mid-fifties with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair with gray streaks at the temples, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines and soft crow's feet, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows with a few gray hairs, light salt-and-pepper stubble, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a black quarter-zip pullover, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close-up on the chrome. Lighting: warm natural light with amber accents. Mood: pride, dream.

Camera: close-up on the chrome · **Lighting:** warm natural light with amber accents · **Mood:** pride, dream · **Action:** admiring the car

☐ Image made

Beat 112 09:07 · ~4.2s · The Protagonist

“$92,000. You park it in the driveway of the house everyone pitied.”

IMAGE PROMPT

The 1967 coupe parked in the driveway of the newly painted Calloway Street house, a price tag $92,000 dangling from the mirror. The protagonist is a man in his mid-fifties with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair with gray streaks at the temples, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines and soft crow's feet, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows with a few gray hairs, light salt-and-pepper stubble, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a black quarter-zip pullover, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: wide establishing shot. Lighting: warm natural light with amber accents. Mood: triumphant, understated.

Camera: wide establishing shot · **Lighting:** warm natural light with amber accents · **Mood:** triumphant, understated · **Action:** leaning on the car

☐ Image made

Beat 113 09:11 · ~4.9s · The Protagonist, The Hardware Store Clerk

“That's when the town notices. At the hardware store, buddy turns back into sir.”

IMAGE PROMPT

The hardware clerk standing up straight and politely saying Yes, sir, the protagonist calm across the counter. The protagonist is a man in his mid-fifties with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair with gray streaks at the temples, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines and soft crow's feet, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows with a few gray hairs, light salt-and-pepper stubble, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a black quarter-zip pullover, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: The hardware store clerk is a chubby man in his forties with a red beard and a backwards cap, wearing a rust-orange store apron. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium two-shot. Lighting: warm natural light with amber accents. Mood: respect restored.

Camera: medium two-shot · **Lighting:** warm natural light with amber accents · **Mood:** respect restored · **Action:** the clerk straightening

☐ Image made

Beat 114 09:16 · ~6.6s · Greg, The Protagonist

“Greg from golf crosses the whole parking lot this time. Hey, stranger, he says. Heard things are looking up.”

IMAGE PROMPT

Greg jogging eagerly across a parking lot toward the protagonist, arms open, a big fake smile. The protagonist is a man in his mid-fifties with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair with gray streaks at the temples, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines and soft crow's feet, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows with a few gray hairs, light salt-and-pepper stubble, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a black quarter-zip pullover, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: Greg is a tanned man in his late fifties with perfect white hair and very white teeth, wearing a pastel golf polo. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: wide shot. Lighting: warm natural light with amber accents. Mood: fake, ironic.

Camera: wide shot · **Lighting:** warm natural light with amber accents · **Mood:** fake, ironic · **Action:** Greg waving

☐ Image made

Beat 115 09:23 · ~5.9s · The Protagonist

“You call Luis. You ask if he wants to start something small. Just the two of you.”

IMAGE PROMPT

The protagonist on the porch calling Luis on the phone, a small sketch of a FLOORING sign in a notebook beside him. The protagonist is a man in his mid-fifties with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair with gray streaks at the temples, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines and soft crow's feet, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows with a few gray hairs, light salt-and-pepper stubble, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a black quarter-zip pullover, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium shot. Lighting: warm natural light with amber accents. Mood: hopeful.

Camera: medium shot · **Lighting:** warm natural light with amber accents · **Mood:** hopeful · **Action:** dialing

☐ Image made

Beat 116 09:29 · ~7.7s · Luis

“Flooring. He's quiet on the phone for a long time. Then he says, Boss, I've been waiting a year for this call.”

IMAGE PROMPT

Luis on the phone in his kitchen, emotional, wiping his eyes with his thumb. Character notes: Luis is a broad-shouldered Latino man in his early forties with a black buzz cut and thick mustache, wearing a gray work polo and dusty work pants. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium close-up. Lighting: warm natural light with amber accents. Mood: loyal, moving.

Camera: medium close-up · **Lighting:** warm natural light with amber accents · **Mood:** loyal, moving · **Action:** Luis smiling through tears

☐ Image made

Beat 117 09:36 · ~5.2s · Eli, The Protagonist

“Eli shows up on a Saturday without being asked. He walks around the coupe twice.”

IMAGE PROMPT

Eli arriving on a Saturday, walking around the 1967 coupe slowly, amazed. The protagonist is a man in his mid-fifties with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair with gray streaks at the temples, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines and soft crow's feet, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows with a few gray hairs, light salt-and-pepper stubble, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a black quarter-zip pullover, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: Eli is a lanky sixteen-year-old boy with messy dark curly hair and earbuds around his neck, wearing a faded maroon hoodie. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium-wide shot. Lighting: warm natural light with amber accents. Mood: reconnection.

Camera: medium-wide shot · **Lighting:** warm natural light with amber accents · **Mood:** reconnection · **Action:** Eli circling the car

☐ Image made

Beat 118 09:42 · ~4.9s · Eli, The Protagonist

“Can I drive it? No, you say. But you can wash it with me.”

IMAGE PROMPT

The protagonist and Eli washing the coupe together, soap suds and a hose, both almost smiling. The protagonist is a man in his mid-fifties with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair with gray streaks at the temples, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines and soft crow's feet, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows with a few gray hairs, light salt-and-pepper stubble, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a black quarter-zip pullover, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: Eli is a lanky sixteen-year-old boy with messy dark curly hair and earbuds around his neck, wearing a faded maroon hoodie. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium two-shot. Lighting: warm natural light with amber accents. Mood: warm bonding.

Camera: medium two-shot · **Lighting:** warm natural light with amber accents · **Mood:** warm bonding · **Action:** scrubbing the hood

☐ Image made

Beat 119 09:46 · ~3.5s · Eli, The Protagonist

“He stays until dark. He doesn't check his phone once.”

IMAGE PROMPT

The sun setting over the driveway as Eli and the protagonist sit on the porch steps, Eli's phone face-down beside him. The protagonist is a man in his mid-fifties with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair with gray streaks at the temples, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines and soft crow's feet, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows with a few gray hairs, light salt-and-pepper stubble, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a black quarter-zip pullover, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: Eli is a lanky sixteen-year-old boy with messy dark curly hair and earbuds around his neck, wearing a faded maroon hoodie. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: wide shot. Lighting: warm natural light with amber accents. Mood: peaceful.

Camera: wide shot · **Lighting:** warm natural light with amber accents · **Mood:** peaceful · **Action:** sitting together

☐ Image made

Beat 120 09:50 · ~5.6s · Dana, The Protagonist

“Dana notices the porch first. Then the paint. Then you. Dad, she says, you look different.”

IMAGE PROMPT

Dana arriving and noticing the repaired porch and fresh paint, then turning to look at her father. The protagonist is a man in his mid-fifties with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair with gray streaks at the temples, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines and soft crow's feet, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows with a few gray hairs, light salt-and-pepper stubble, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a black quarter-zip pullover, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: Dana is a twenty-six-year-old woman with dark curly hair in a low bun and a small silver nose stud, wearing a long mustard wool coat over a black turtleneck. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium-wide shot. Lighting: warm natural light with amber accents. Mood: surprised.

Camera: medium-wide shot · **Lighting:** warm natural light with amber accents · **Mood:** surprised · **Action:** Dana pausing

☐ Image made

Beat 121 09:56 · ~6.3s · Dana, The Protagonist

“You don't tell her about the money. Not yet. She stays for dinner. She takes her coat off.”

IMAGE PROMPT

Dana at the dinner table, her mustard coat hung on the chair behind her, laughing with her father. The protagonist is a man in his mid-fifties with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair with gray streaks at the temples, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines and soft crow's feet, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows with a few gray hairs, light salt-and-pepper stubble, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a black quarter-zip pullover, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: Dana is a twenty-six-year-old woman with dark curly hair in a low bun and a small silver nose stud, wearing a black turtleneck, her mustard coat hung on the chair behind her. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium two-shot. Lighting: warm natural light with amber accents. Mood: healed, warm.

Camera: medium two-shot · **Lighting:** warm natural light with amber accents · **Mood:** healed, warm · **Action:** Dana taking off her coat

☐ Image made

Two Exclamation Points

Age 56 · She comes back

Beat 122 10:02 · ~2.1s · Insert / establishing

“Renée's first text comes in June.”

IMAGE PROMPT

Close-up of the protagonist's phone lighting up with a text from RENÉE in June. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: phone screen insert. Lighting: soft warm daylight with cool shadows. Mood: suspicious.

Camera: phone screen insert · **Lighting:** soft warm daylight with cool shadows · **Mood:** suspicious · **Action:** the phone buzzing

☐ Image made

Beat 123 10:04 · ~2.8s · Insert / establishing

“Hey. Been thinking about you. Hope you're well.”

IMAGE PROMPT

Phone text bubble reading Hey. Been thinking about you. Hope you're well.. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: phone screen insert. Lighting: soft warm daylight with cool shadows. Mood: calculated.

Camera: phone screen insert · **Lighting:** soft warm daylight with cool shadows · **Mood:** calculated · **Action:** message appearing

☐ Image made

Beat 124 10:07 · ~3.5s · The Protagonist

“You read it at a red light. You don't answer.”

IMAGE PROMPT

The protagonist in his black truck at a red light, glancing at the phone on the dashboard, not answering. The protagonist is a man in his mid-fifties with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair with gray streaks at the temples, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines and soft crow's feet, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows with a few gray hairs, light salt-and-pepper stubble, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a black quarter-zip pullover, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium shot through the windshield. Lighting: soft warm daylight with cool shadows. Mood: indifferent.

Camera: medium shot through the windshield · **Lighting:** soft warm daylight with cool shadows · **Mood:** indifferent · **Action:** eyes back on the road

☐ Image made

Beat 125 10:10 · ~5.6s · Insert / establishing

“The second text comes a week later. Eli says you got a new car. That's great!!”

IMAGE PROMPT

Phone insert of a second text: Eli says you got a new car. That's great!!. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: phone screen insert. Lighting: soft warm daylight with cool shadows. Mood: fake enthusiasm.

Camera: phone screen insert · **Lighting:** soft warm daylight with cool shadows · **Mood:** fake enthusiasm · **Action:** message appearing

☐ Image made

Beat 126 10:16 · ~6.3s · The Protagonist

“Proud of you. Two exclamation points. In twenty-nine years, she never once used two exclamation points with you.”

IMAGE PROMPT

The protagonist staring flatly at the phone, the two exclamation points enlarged and floating like little daggers. The protagonist is a man in his mid-fifties with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair with gray streaks at the temples, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines and soft crow's feet, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows with a few gray hairs, light salt-and-pepper stubble, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a black quarter-zip pullover, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium close-up. Lighting: soft warm daylight with cool shadows. Mood: ironic.

Camera: medium close-up · **Lighting:** soft warm daylight with cool shadows · **Mood:** ironic · **Action:** raising an eyebrow

☐ Image made

Beat 127 10:22 · ~3.8s · Renée, The Protagonist

“Then she starts showing up. A casserole you didn't ask for.”

IMAGE PROMPT

Renée on the protagonist's porch holding a casserole dish with an oven mitt, smiling too widely. The protagonist is a man in his mid-fifties with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair with gray streaks at the temples, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines and soft crow's feet, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows with a few gray hairs, light salt-and-pepper stubble, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a black quarter-zip pullover, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: Renée is a slim, polished woman in her early fifties with a sleek honey-blonde bob, wearing a camel trench coat, gold jewelry and oversized sunglasses pushed up on her head. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium two-shot at the door. Lighting: soft warm daylight with cool shadows. Mood: awkward, manipulative.

Camera: medium two-shot at the door · **Lighting:** soft warm daylight with cool shadows · **Mood:** awkward, manipulative · **Action:** offering the casserole

☐ Image made

Beat 128 10:26 · ~6.6s · Renée

“Standing on your new porch, looking at the coupe, looking at the paint, doing a different kind of math.”

IMAGE PROMPT

Renée standing on the new porch eyeing the coupe and the fresh paint, small dollar signs reflected in her sunglasses. Character notes: Renée is a slim, polished woman in her early fifties with a sleek honey-blonde bob, wearing a camel trench coat, gold jewelry and oversized sunglasses pushed up on her head. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium-wide shot. Lighting: soft warm daylight with cool shadows. Mood: calculating.

Camera: medium-wide shot · **Lighting:** soft warm daylight with cool shadows · **Mood:** calculating · **Action:** Renée scanning the property

☐ Image made

Beat 129 10:33 · ~4.9s · Renée, The Protagonist

“Maybe we were too quick, she says. Maybe we should talk. For the kids.”

IMAGE PROMPT

Renée leaning on the porch rail, softening her voice, saying Maybe we should talk, while the protagonist stays in the doorway. The protagonist is a man in his mid-fifties with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair with gray streaks at the temples, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines and soft crow's feet, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows with a few gray hairs, light salt-and-pepper stubble, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a black quarter-zip pullover, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: Renée is a slim, polished woman in her early fifties with a sleek honey-blonde bob, wearing a camel trench coat, gold jewelry and oversized sunglasses pushed up on her head. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium two-shot. Lighting: soft warm daylight with cool shadows. Mood: manipulative.

Camera: medium two-shot · **Lighting:** soft warm daylight with cool shadows · **Mood:** manipulative · **Action:** Renée touching her hair

☐ Image made

Beat 130 10:37 · ~7.0s · Renée

“She's driving the convertible. There's a dent in the bumper she hasn't fixed. Later, you hear the SUV is gone.”

IMAGE PROMPT

Renée's silver convertible in the driveway with a visible dented bumper, a faded memory inset of the white SUV with a SOLD AT A LOSS sticker. Character notes: Renée is a slim, polished woman in her early fifties with a sleek honey-blonde bob, wearing a camel trench coat, gold jewelry and oversized sunglasses pushed up on her head. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium-wide shot. Lighting: soft warm daylight with cool shadows. Mood: decline.

Camera: medium-wide shot · **Lighting:** soft warm daylight with cool shadows · **Mood:** decline · **Action:** Renée getting into the car

☐ Image made

Beat 131 10:44 · ~5.9s · Renée

“Sold back at a loss. Portugal went on a credit card. The kitchen went on another one.”

IMAGE PROMPT

Split-screen of credit card statements: PORTUGAL TRIP and KITCHEN REMODEL, red overdue stamps on both. Character notes: Renée is a slim, polished woman in her early fifties with a sleek honey-blonde bob, wearing a camel trench coat, gold jewelry and oversized sunglasses pushed up on her head. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: split-screen insert. Lighting: soft warm daylight with cool shadows. Mood: consequence.

Camera: split-screen insert · **Lighting:** soft warm daylight with cool shadows · **Mood:** consequence · **Action:** papers piling up

☐ Image made

Beat 132 10:50 · ~4.9s · Renée

“Five hundred thousand dollars sounds like forever. Until you spend it like it is.”

IMAGE PROMPT

Visual metaphor: a large money bag labeled $500,000 with a hole in the bottom leaking coins as Renée walks. Character notes: Renée is a slim, polished woman in her early fifties with a sleek honey-blonde bob, wearing a camel trench coat, gold jewelry and oversized sunglasses pushed up on her head. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: wide symbolic shot. Lighting: soft warm daylight with cool shadows. Mood: foolish waste.

Camera: wide symbolic shot · **Lighting:** soft warm daylight with cool shadows · **Mood:** foolish waste · **Action:** coins trailing behind

☐ Image made

Beat 133 10:55 · ~5.6s · The Protagonist, Renée

“You tell her you're doing fine on your own. You say it kindly. You mean it.”

IMAGE PROMPT

The protagonist on the porch speaking kindly but firmly to Renée, a calm hand on the door. The protagonist is a man in his mid-fifties with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair with gray streaks at the temples, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines and soft crow's feet, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows with a few gray hairs, light salt-and-pepper stubble, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a black quarter-zip pullover, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: Renée is a slim, polished woman in her early fifties with a sleek honey-blonde bob, wearing a camel trench coat, gold jewelry and oversized sunglasses pushed up on her head. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium two-shot. Lighting: soft warm daylight with cool shadows. Mood: dignified.

Camera: medium two-shot · **Lighting:** soft warm daylight with cool shadows · **Mood:** dignified · **Action:** the protagonist gently refusing

☐ Image made

Beat 134 11:01 · ~4.9s · The Process Server, The Protagonist

“Three weeks later, a process server hands you an envelope on your own porch.”

IMAGE PROMPT

A process server handing a large manila envelope to the protagonist on his own porch. The protagonist is a man in his mid-fifties with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair with gray streaks at the temples, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines and soft crow's feet, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows with a few gray hairs, light salt-and-pepper stubble, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a black quarter-zip pullover, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: The process server is a stocky expressionless man in his forties with a shaved head and a navy windbreaker. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium two-shot. Lighting: soft warm daylight with cool shadows. Mood: ominous.

Camera: medium two-shot · **Lighting:** soft warm daylight with cool shadows · **Mood:** ominous · **Action:** the envelope being handed over

☐ Image made

STAGE 11 · BEATS 135–152

Courtroom 4B, Again

Age 56 · Motion denied

Beat 135 11:06 · ~3.5s · The Protagonist

“Courtroom 4B. Same carpet. Same coffee smell. Sixteen months later.”

IMAGE PROMPT

Courtroom 4B again: the same stained carpet and coffee cup, the protagonist walking in wearing a dark tailored jacket. The protagonist is a man in his mid-fifties with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair with gray streaks at the temples, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines and soft crow's feet, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows with a few gray hairs, light salt-and-pepper stubble, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a dark tailored jacket over a black tee, a worn gold pen in his breast pocket, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: wide one-point perspective shot. Lighting: the same courtroom fluorescents, but warm golden morning sun through tall windows falling across the protagonist. Mood: déjà vu, confident.

Camera: wide one-point perspective shot · **Lighting:** the same courtroom fluorescents, but warm golden morning sun through tall windows falling across the protagonist · **Mood:** déjà vu, confident · **Action:** walking down the aisle

☐ Image made

Beat 136 11:09 · ~5.9s · Renée's New Lawyer, Renée

“Renée's new lawyer is younger, sharper and more expensive. He stands up and talks about hidden assets.”

IMAGE PROMPT

Renée's new lawyer, young and slick in an expensive black suit, standing and gesturing dramatically, Renée beside him. Character notes: Renée's new lawyer is a slick man in his early thirties with an undercut, wearing an expensive fitted black suit and a slim silver tie; Renée is a slim, polished woman in her early fifties with a sleek honey-blonde bob and pearl stud earrings, wearing a cream blazer over a white silk blouse. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium-wide shot. Lighting: the same courtroom fluorescents, but warm golden morning sun through tall windows falling across the protagonist. Mood: aggressive.

Camera: medium-wide shot · **Lighting:** the same courtroom fluorescents, but warm golden morning sun through tall windows falling across the protagonist · **Mood:** aggressive · **Action:** the lawyer pointing

☐ Image made

Beat 137 11:15 · ~6.6s · Renée's New Lawyer

“About concealment during the marriage. About a sixteen-year-old son who deserves stability. He uses the word fair eleven times.”

IMAGE PROMPT

The lawyer mid-speech with the word FAIR floating above him eleven times like a cloud. Character notes: Renée's new lawyer is a slick man in his early thirties with an undercut, wearing an expensive fitted black suit and a slim silver tie. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium shot. Lighting: the same courtroom fluorescents, but warm golden morning sun through tall windows falling across the protagonist. Mood: theatrical, hollow.

Camera: medium shot · **Lighting:** the same courtroom fluorescents, but warm golden morning sun through tall windows falling across the protagonist · **Mood:** theatrical, hollow · **Action:** the lawyer spreading his hands

☐ Image made

Beat 138 11:22 · ~6.3s · Renée's New Lawyer, The Protagonist

“You count. We are asking the court, he says, to reopen the settlement and order an equal division.”

IMAGE PROMPT

The lawyer pointing at the protagonist, a document reading MOTION TO REOPEN — 50/50 in his other hand. The protagonist is a man in his mid-fifties with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair with gray streaks at the temples, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines and soft crow's feet, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows with a few gray hairs, light salt-and-pepper stubble, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a dark tailored jacket over a black tee, a worn gold pen in his breast pocket, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: Renée's new lawyer is a slick man in his early thirties with an undercut, wearing an expensive fitted black suit and a slim silver tie. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: over-the-shoulder shot from behind the protagonist. Lighting: the same courtroom fluorescents, but warm golden morning sun through tall windows falling across the protagonist. Mood: high stakes.

Camera: over-the-shoulder shot from behind the protagonist · **Lighting:** the same courtroom fluorescents, but warm golden morning sun through tall windows falling across the protagonist · **Mood:** high stakes · **Action:** the lawyer demanding

☐ Image made

Beat 139 11:28 · ~2.4s · Renée's New Lawyer, Renée

“Fifty-fifty. For the sake of the children.”

IMAGE PROMPT

The lawyer's hand slicing an imaginary line down the middle, a 50/50 graphic splitting a pile of money in half. Character notes: Renée's new lawyer is a slick man in his early thirties with an undercut, wearing an expensive fitted black suit and a slim silver tie; Renée is a slim, polished woman in her early fifties with a sleek honey-blonde bob and pearl stud earrings, wearing a cream blazer over a white silk blouse. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium shot with graphic overlay. Lighting: the same courtroom fluorescents, but warm golden morning sun through tall windows falling across the protagonist. Mood: greedy.

Camera: medium shot with graphic overlay · **Lighting:** the same courtroom fluorescents, but warm golden morning sun through tall windows falling across the protagonist · **Mood:** greedy · **Action:** Renée nodding

☐ Image made

Beat 140 11:30 · ~3.8s · Renée, The Protagonist

“Renée looks at you now. Not at the ceiling. At you.”

IMAGE PROMPT

Renée now turned in her seat staring directly at the protagonist, no longer at the ceiling. The protagonist is a man in his mid-fifties with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair with gray streaks at the temples, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines and soft crow's feet, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows with a few gray hairs, light salt-and-pepper stubble, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a dark tailored jacket over a black tee, a worn gold pen in his breast pocket, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: Renée is a slim, polished woman in her early fifties with a sleek honey-blonde bob and pearl stud earrings, wearing a cream blazer over a white silk blouse. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close-up on Renée. Lighting: the same courtroom fluorescents, but warm golden morning sun through tall windows falling across the protagonist. Mood: tense.

Camera: close-up on Renée · **Lighting:** the same courtroom fluorescents, but warm golden morning sun through tall windows falling across the protagonist · **Mood:** tense · **Action:** Renée locking eyes

☐ Image made

Beat 141 11:34 · ~4.9s · The Judge, The Protagonist

“The judge, the same judge, turns your way. Sir? Anything you'd like to say?”

IMAGE PROMPT

The judge on the bench turning to the protagonist, eyebrows raised. The protagonist is a man in his mid-fifties with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair with gray streaks at the temples, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines and soft crow's feet, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows with a few gray hairs, light salt-and-pepper stubble, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a dark tailored jacket over a black tee, a worn gold pen in his breast pocket, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: The judge is a composed Black woman in her early sixties with short natural gray hair and reading glasses on a beaded chain, wearing a black robe. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium shot of the bench. Lighting: the same courtroom fluorescents, but warm golden morning sun through tall windows falling across the protagonist. Mood: expectant.

Camera: medium shot of the bench · **Lighting:** the same courtroom fluorescents, but warm golden morning sun through tall windows falling across the protagonist · **Mood:** expectant · **Action:** the judge looking over her glasses

☐ Image made

Beat 142 11:39 · ~4.2s · Your Lawyer, The Protagonist

“Your lawyer starts to stand. You put a hand on his arm.”

IMAGE PROMPT

The protagonist's lawyer starting to rise, the protagonist placing a calm hand on his arm. The protagonist is a man in his mid-fifties with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair with gray streaks at the temples, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines and soft crow's feet, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows with a few gray hairs, light salt-and-pepper stubble, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a dark tailored jacket over a black tee, a worn gold pen in his breast pocket, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: His lawyer is a thin older man in his late sixties with a white goatee and half-moon glasses, wearing a rumpled brown suit. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium two-shot. Lighting: the same courtroom fluorescents, but warm golden morning sun through tall windows falling across the protagonist. Mood: controlled.

Camera: medium two-shot · **Lighting:** the same courtroom fluorescents, but warm golden morning sun through tall windows falling across the protagonist · **Mood:** controlled · **Action:** gently holding him back

☐ Image made

Beat 143 11:43 · ~5.6s · The Protagonist

“You don't need a speech. You've had sixteen months of quiet to decide what to say.”

IMAGE PROMPT

The protagonist standing slowly, a montage of past cold, lonely nights faintly reflected behind him. The protagonist is a man in his mid-fifties with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair with gray streaks at the temples, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines and soft crow's feet, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows with a few gray hairs, light salt-and-pepper stubble, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a dark tailored jacket over a black tee, a worn gold pen in his breast pocket, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium close-up. Lighting: the same courtroom fluorescents, but warm golden morning sun through tall windows falling across the protagonist. Mood: composed, earned.

Camera: medium close-up · **Lighting:** the same courtroom fluorescents, but warm golden morning sun through tall windows falling across the protagonist · **Mood:** composed, earned · **Action:** buttoning his jacket

☐ Image made

Beat 144 11:49 · ~5.6s · The Protagonist

“Your Honor, you say. That money was never mine during the marriage. It was my grandfather's.”

IMAGE PROMPT

The protagonist addressing the court, posture straight, the gold pen visible in his breast pocket. The protagonist is a man in his mid-fifties with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair with gray streaks at the temples, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines and soft crow's feet, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows with a few gray hairs, light salt-and-pepper stubble, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a dark tailored jacket over a black tee, a worn gold pen in his breast pocket, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: low-angle medium shot. Lighting: the same courtroom fluorescents, but warm golden morning sun through tall windows falling across the protagonist. Mood: dignified, powerful.

Camera: low-angle medium shot · **Lighting:** the same courtroom fluorescents, but warm golden morning sun through tall windows falling across the protagonist · **Mood:** dignified, powerful · **Action:** speaking clearly

☐ Image made

Beat 145 11:55 · ~5.2s · The Protagonist

“In his name, in his trust, from 1999 until this January. I didn't earn it.”

IMAGE PROMPT

The protagonist speaking, a ghostly image of Walter and the old trust envelope dated 1999 behind him. The protagonist is a man in his mid-fifties with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair with gray streaks at the temples, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines and soft crow's feet, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows with a few gray hairs, light salt-and-pepper stubble, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a dark tailored jacket over a black tee, a worn gold pen in his breast pocket, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium shot with ghostly overlay. Lighting: the same courtroom fluorescents, but warm golden morning sun through tall windows falling across the protagonist. Mood: truthful.

Camera: medium shot with ghostly overlay · **Lighting:** the same courtroom fluorescents, but warm golden morning sun through tall windows falling across the protagonist · **Mood:** truthful · **Action:** gesturing

☐ Image made

Beat 146 12:00 · ~6.6s · The Protagonist

“I didn't hide it. I didn't touch it. I received it eight months after this court finalized our divorce.”

IMAGE PROMPT

The protagonist with three calm statements floating as plaques: DIDN'T HIDE IT, DIDN'T TOUCH IT, AFTER THE DIVORCE. The protagonist is a man in his mid-fifties with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair with gray streaks at the temples, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines and soft crow's feet, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows with a few gray hairs, light salt-and-pepper stubble, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a dark tailored jacket over a black tee, a worn gold pen in his breast pocket, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium shot with floating text. Lighting: the same courtroom fluorescents, but warm golden morning sun through tall windows falling across the protagonist. Mood: calm conviction.

Camera: medium shot with floating text · **Lighting:** the same courtroom fluorescents, but warm golden morning sun through tall windows falling across the protagonist · **Mood:** calm conviction · **Action:** counting off on his fingers

☐ Image made

Beat 147 12:06 · ~7.3s · Your Lawyer, The Court Clerk

“Your lawyer hands the clerk the trust documents. Dated. Notarized. Thomas Hollis's signature from twenty-seven years ago, steady as a ruler.”

IMAGE PROMPT

The protagonist's lawyer handing the clerk old trust documents with official notary seals and an old steady signature. Character notes: His lawyer is a thin older man in his late sixties with a white goatee and half-moon glasses, wearing a rumpled brown suit; the court clerk is a bored middle-aged man with thinning brown hair, a cardigan and a lanyard badge. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close two-shot on the papers. Lighting: the same courtroom fluorescents, but warm golden morning sun through tall windows falling across the protagonist. Mood: decisive proof.

Camera: close two-shot on the papers · **Lighting:** the same courtroom fluorescents, but warm golden morning sun through tall windows falling across the protagonist · **Mood:** decisive proof · **Action:** the documents passing hands

☐ Image made

Beat 148 12:14 · ~6.6s · The Protagonist, Eli

“And my children, you say, don't need anything divided. Eli's college is already paid for, directly to the school.”

IMAGE PROMPT

The protagonist speaking, a paid tuition receipt showing PAID IN FULL with Eli's face beside it. The protagonist is a man in his mid-fifties with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair with gray streaks at the temples, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines and soft crow's feet, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows with a few gray hairs, light salt-and-pepper stubble, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a dark tailored jacket over a black tee, a worn gold pen in his breast pocket, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: Eli is a lanky sixteen-year-old boy with messy dark curly hair and earbuds around his neck, wearing a faded maroon hoodie. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium shot with inset. Lighting: the same courtroom fluorescents, but warm golden morning sun through tall windows falling across the protagonist. Mood: protective father.

Camera: medium shot with inset · **Lighting:** the same courtroom fluorescents, but warm golden morning sun through tall windows falling across the protagonist · **Mood:** protective father · **Action:** holding up a receipt

☐ Image made

Beat 149 12:20 · ~4.5s · The Protagonist, Dana

“Dana's student loans were cleared last month. The receipts are in the folder.”

IMAGE PROMPT

A student loan statement for Dana stamped PAID with a receipt folder on the table. The protagonist is a man in his mid-fifties with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair with gray streaks at the temples, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines and soft crow's feet, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows with a few gray hairs, light salt-and-pepper stubble, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a dark tailored jacket over a black tee, a worn gold pen in his breast pocket, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: Dana is a twenty-six-year-old woman with dark curly hair in a low bun and a small silver nose stud, wearing a long mustard wool coat over a black turtleneck. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close-up insert. Lighting: the same courtroom fluorescents, but warm golden morning sun through tall windows falling across the protagonist. Mood: responsibility.

Camera: close-up insert · **Lighting:** the same courtroom fluorescents, but warm golden morning sun through tall windows falling across the protagonist · **Mood:** responsibility · **Action:** sliding the folder forward

☐ Image made

Beat 150 12:25 · ~6.6s · The Judge

“The judge reads for a long time. The room is so quiet you can hear the fluorescent lights buzz.”

IMAGE PROMPT

The judge reading documents in silence, the fluorescent lights above buzzing with small zigzag lines. Character notes: The judge is a composed Black woman in her early sixties with short natural gray hair and reading glasses on a beaded chain, wearing a black robe. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium close-up. Lighting: the same courtroom fluorescents, but warm golden morning sun through tall windows falling across the protagonist. Mood: tense silence.

Camera: medium close-up · **Lighting:** the same courtroom fluorescents, but warm golden morning sun through tall windows falling across the protagonist · **Mood:** tense silence · **Action:** flipping pages

☐ Image made

Beat 151 12:32 · ~2.1s · The Judge

“Then she takes off her glasses.”

IMAGE PROMPT

The judge slowly removing her reading glasses. Character notes: The judge is a composed Black woman in her early sixties with short natural gray hair and reading glasses on a beaded chain, wearing a black robe. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close-up. Lighting: the same courtroom fluorescents, but warm golden morning sun through tall windows falling across the protagonist. Mood: decisive.

Camera: close-up · **Lighting:** the same courtroom fluorescents, but warm golden morning sun through tall windows falling across the protagonist · **Mood:** decisive · **Action:** glasses coming off

☐ Image made

Beat 152 12:34 · ~5.2s · The Judge, The Protagonist

“Motion denied. Two words. Ten seconds. Less time than your signature took the first time.”

IMAGE PROMPT

The judge's gavel striking with the words MOTION DENIED, the protagonist in the foreground calm. The protagonist is a man in his mid-fifties with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair with gray streaks at the temples, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines and soft crow's feet, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows with a few gray hairs, light salt-and-pepper stubble, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a dark tailored jacket over a black tee, a worn gold pen in his breast pocket, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: The judge is a composed Black woman in her early sixties with short natural gray hair and reading glasses on a beaded chain, wearing a black robe. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: low-angle medium shot. Lighting: the same courtroom fluorescents, but warm golden morning sun through tall windows falling across the protagonist. Mood: victory, final.

Camera: low-angle medium shot · **Lighting:** the same courtroom fluorescents, but warm golden morning sun through tall windows falling across the protagonist · **Mood:** victory, final · **Action:** gavel coming down

☐ Image made

STAGE 12 · BEATS 153–161

Twenty-Nine Years

Age 56 · The elevator

Beat 153 12:39 · ~6.6s · The Protagonist, Renée

“You don't look at Renée right away. When you finally do, she isn't angry. That's what you didn't expect.”

IMAGE PROMPT

The protagonist turning slowly toward Renée, who sits still, not angry but stunned. The protagonist is a man in his mid-fifties with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair with gray streaks at the temples, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines and soft crow's feet, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows with a few gray hairs, light salt-and-pepper stubble, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a dark tailored jacket over a black tee, a worn gold pen in his breast pocket, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: Renée is a slim, polished woman in her early fifties with a sleek honey-blonde bob and pearl stud earrings, wearing a cream blazer over a white silk blouse. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium two-shot. Lighting: cool courthouse hallway light with a warm pool of light on the protagonist. Mood: unexpected.

Camera: medium two-shot · **Lighting:** cool courthouse hallway light with a warm pool of light on the protagonist · **Mood:** unexpected · **Action:** turning his head

☐ Image made

Beat 154 12:46 · ~1.4s · Renée

“She just looks small.”

IMAGE PROMPT

Renée looking small and shrunken in her seat, the courtroom looming large around her. Character notes: Renée is a slim, polished woman in her early fifties with a sleek honey-blonde bob and pearl stud earrings, wearing a cream blazer over a white silk blouse. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: high-angle shot. Lighting: cool courthouse hallway light with a warm pool of light on the protagonist. Mood: defeated.

Camera: high-angle shot · **Lighting:** cool courthouse hallway light with a warm pool of light on the protagonist · **Mood:** defeated · **Action:** shoulders sinking

☐ Image made

Beat 155 12:47 · ~7.3s · Renée

“Like someone who walked out of a house with half the furniture and only now found out it had a basement.”

IMAGE PROMPT

Visual metaphor: Renée walking out of a big house carrying half the furniture, while a lit basement door glows with gold behind her. Character notes: Renée is a slim, polished woman in her early fifties with a sleek honey-blonde bob and pearl stud earrings, wearing a cream blazer over a white silk blouse. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: wide symbolic shot. Lighting: cool courthouse hallway light with a warm pool of light on the protagonist. Mood: realization, regret.

Camera: wide symbolic shot · **Lighting:** cool courthouse hallway light with a warm pool of light on the protagonist · **Mood:** realization, regret · **Action:** looking back at the glow

☐ Image made

Beat 156 12:54 · ~5.9s · Renée, The Protagonist

“She catches you at the elevator. Twenty-nine years, she says. Twenty-nine years, and you never told me.”

IMAGE PROMPT

Renée catching up to the protagonist at the courthouse elevator, eyes wet, saying Twenty-nine years. The protagonist is a man in his mid-fifties with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair with gray streaks at the temples, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines and soft crow's feet, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows with a few gray hairs, light salt-and-pepper stubble, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a dark tailored jacket over a black tee, a worn gold pen in his breast pocket, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: Renée is a slim, polished woman in her early fifties with a sleek honey-blonde bob and pearl stud earrings, wearing a cream blazer over a white silk blouse. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium two-shot. Lighting: cool courthouse hallway light with a warm pool of light on the protagonist. Mood: painful, raw.

Camera: medium two-shot · **Lighting:** cool courthouse hallway light with a warm pool of light on the protagonist · **Mood:** painful, raw · **Action:** Renée grabbing his sleeve

☐ Image made

Beat 157 13:00 · ~5.2s · The Protagonist

“You think about the cold kitchen. The furnace. The crackers. Eli's texts that stopped coming.”

IMAGE PROMPT

The protagonist's memories floating like photographs: the cold kitchen, the dead furnace, crackers, Eli's unanswered texts. The protagonist is a man in his mid-fifties with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair with gray streaks at the temples, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines and soft crow's feet, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows with a few gray hairs, light salt-and-pepper stubble, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a dark tailored jacket over a black tee, a worn gold pen in his breast pocket, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium shot with floating memory panels. Lighting: cool courthouse hallway light with a warm pool of light on the protagonist. Mood: reflective.

Camera: medium shot with floating memory panels · **Lighting:** cool courthouse hallway light with a warm pool of light on the protagonist · **Mood:** reflective · **Action:** the protagonist looking down

☐ Image made

Beat 158 13:05 · ~2.8s · The Church Woman

“The woman at church who called you brave.”

IMAGE PROMPT

A faded memory panel of the church woman patting his arm with the word BRAVE. Character notes: The church woman is a petite woman in her seventies with a silver perm and a pastel floral dress. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: memory insert. Lighting: cool courthouse hallway light with a warm pool of light on the protagonist. Mood: bitter irony.

Camera: memory insert · **Lighting:** cool courthouse hallway light with a warm pool of light on the protagonist · **Mood:** bitter irony · **Action:** the pat

☐ Image made

Beat 159 13:08 · ~6.3s · The Protagonist, Renée

“No, you say. I didn't. And standing there, you finally answer the question you've been asking since November.”

IMAGE PROMPT

The protagonist calmly facing Renée at the elevator, answering simply No, I didn't. The protagonist is a man in his mid-fifties with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair with gray streaks at the temples, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines and soft crow's feet, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows with a few gray hairs, light salt-and-pepper stubble, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a dark tailored jacket over a black tee, a worn gold pen in his breast pocket, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: Renée is a slim, polished woman in her early fifties with a sleek honey-blonde bob and pearl stud earrings, wearing a cream blazer over a white silk blouse. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium close two-shot. Lighting: cool courthouse hallway light with a warm pool of light on the protagonist. Mood: calm, final.

Camera: medium close two-shot · **Lighting:** cool courthouse hallway light with a warm pool of light on the protagonist · **Mood:** calm, final · **Action:** the elevator doors opening

☐ Image made

Beat 160 13:14 · ~3.8s · The Protagonist

“You didn't tell her because the not-telling was the real inheritance.”

IMAGE PROMPT

The protagonist holding Walter's gold pen, a translucent envelope behind it labeled THE REAL INHERITANCE. The protagonist is a man in his mid-fifties with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair with gray streaks at the temples, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines and soft crow's feet, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows with a few gray hairs, light salt-and-pepper stubble, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a dark tailored jacket over a black tee, a worn gold pen in his breast pocket, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close-up. Lighting: cool courthouse hallway light with a warm pool of light on the protagonist. Mood: revelation.

Camera: close-up · **Lighting:** cool courthouse hallway light with a warm pool of light on the protagonist · **Mood:** revelation · **Action:** looking at the pen

☐ Image made

Beat 161 13:18 · ~4.2s · The Protagonist

“It let you see exactly who stayed when the number was zero.”

IMAGE PROMPT

The protagonist stepping into the elevator, a faint row of silhouettes behind him of the few people who stayed: Luis, Dana and Eli. The protagonist is a man in his mid-fifties with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair with gray streaks at the temples, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines and soft crow's feet, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows with a few gray hairs, light salt-and-pepper stubble, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a dark tailored jacket over a black tee, a worn gold pen in his breast pocket, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium shot. Lighting: cool courthouse hallway light with a warm pool of light on the protagonist. Mood: clarity, peace.

Camera: medium shot · **Lighting:** cool courthouse hallway light with a warm pool of light on the protagonist · **Mood:** clarity, peace · **Action:** the doors closing

☐ Image made

STAGE 13 · BEATS 162–168

The Stain

Age 56 · Not tonight

Beat 162 13:23 · ~6.6s · The Protagonist

“That night, you sit on the porch on Calloway Street. The coupe ticks as it cools in the driveway.”

IMAGE PROMPT

The protagonist sitting on the repaired Calloway Street porch at night, the 1967 coupe ticking in the driveway. The protagonist is a man in his mid-fifties with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair with gray streaks at the temples, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines and soft crow's feet, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows with a few gray hairs, light salt-and-pepper stubble, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a dark tailored jacket over a black tee, a worn gold pen in his breast pocket, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: wide shot. Lighting: warm porch-lamp pools against a cool blue night. Mood: peaceful.

Camera: wide shot · **Lighting:** warm porch-lamp pools against a cool blue night · **Mood:** peaceful · **Action:** sitting back

☐ Image made

Beat 163 13:29 · ~6.6s · Eli, Dana

“Inside, Eli and Dana are arguing over a board game neither of them has played since they were kids.”

IMAGE PROMPT

Through the window, Eli and Dana laughing and arguing over an old board game at the kitchen table. Character notes: Eli is a lanky sixteen-year-old boy with messy dark curly hair and earbuds around his neck, wearing a faded maroon hoodie; Dana is a twenty-six-year-old woman with dark curly hair in a low bun and a small silver nose stud, wearing a long mustard wool coat over a black turtleneck. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium shot through the window. Lighting: warm porch-lamp pools against a cool blue night. Mood: warm, healed.

Camera: medium shot through the window · **Lighting:** warm porch-lamp pools against a cool blue night · **Mood:** warm, healed · **Action:** Dana pointing at the board

☐ Image made

Beat 164 13:36 · ~6.6s · The Protagonist

“You walk into the bedroom and look up. The stain is still there. Brown. Shaped almost like a hand.”

IMAGE PROMPT

The protagonist in the bedroom looking up at the hand-shaped stain on the ceiling. The protagonist is a man in his mid-fifties with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair with gray streaks at the temples, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines and soft crow's feet, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows with a few gray hairs, light salt-and-pepper stubble, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a dark tailored jacket over a black tee, a worn gold pen in his breast pocket, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: low-angle shot. Lighting: warm porch-lamp pools against a cool blue night. Mood: reflective.

Camera: low-angle shot · **Lighting:** warm porch-lamp pools against a cool blue night · **Mood:** reflective · **Action:** looking up

☐ Image made

Beat 165 13:42 · ~2.4s · The Protagonist

“Tomorrow, you'll paint over it. Not tonight.”

IMAGE PROMPT

The protagonist holding a paint can by the bedroom door, deciding to wait. The protagonist is a man in his mid-fifties with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair with gray streaks at the temples, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines and soft crow's feet, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows with a few gray hairs, light salt-and-pepper stubble, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a dark tailored jacket over a black tee, a worn gold pen in his breast pocket, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium shot. Lighting: warm porch-lamp pools against a cool blue night. Mood: bittersweet.

Camera: medium shot · **Lighting:** warm porch-lamp pools against a cool blue night · **Mood:** bittersweet · **Action:** setting the paint can down

☐ Image made

Beat 166 13:45 · ~6.3s · The Protagonist

“Here's what nobody tells you about losing half at fifty-five. People measure you by what they can see.”

IMAGE PROMPT

Visual metaphor: the protagonist walking through the town while people judge him by floating price tags over his head. The protagonist is a man in his mid-fifties with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair with gray streaks at the temples, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines and soft crow's feet, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows with a few gray hairs, light salt-and-pepper stubble, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a dark tailored jacket over a black tee, a worn gold pen in his breast pocket, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: wide symbolic shot. Lighting: warm porch-lamp pools against a cool blue night. Mood: observational.

Camera: wide symbolic shot · **Lighting:** warm porch-lamp pools against a cool blue night · **Mood:** observational · **Action:** walking calmly

☐ Image made

Beat 167 13:51 · ~7.3s · The Protagonist

“Most of them count wrong. And the ones who come back when the number changes were never coming back for you.”

IMAGE PROMPT

The protagonist looking at a crowd of faces with dollar-sign eyes drifting back toward him, while he stands still. The protagonist is a man in his mid-fifties with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair with gray streaks at the temples, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines and soft crow's feet, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows with a few gray hairs, light salt-and-pepper stubble, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a dark tailored jacket over a black tee, a worn gold pen in his breast pocket, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium-wide shot. Lighting: warm porch-lamp pools against a cool blue night. Mood: cold truth.

Camera: medium-wide shot · **Lighting:** warm porch-lamp pools against a cool blue night · **Mood:** cold truth · **Action:** not moving

☐ Image made

Beat 168 13:58 · ~1.0s · The Protagonist

“Just the number.”

IMAGE PROMPT

Final shot: the protagonist sitting alone on the porch at night, a single number glowing faintly on the dark street. The protagonist is a man in his mid-fifties with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair with gray streaks at the temples, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines and soft crow's feet, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows with a few gray hairs, light salt-and-pepper stubble, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a dark tailored jacket over a black tee, a worn gold pen in his breast pocket, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: wide shot. Lighting: warm porch-lamp pools against a cool blue night. Mood: cold, final.

Camera: wide shot · **Lighting:** warm porch-lamp pools against a cool blue night · **Mood:** cold, final · **Action:** staring into the night

☐ Image made